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Dwarka pond tragedy: 3 children drown; inquiry into safety lapses



NATION: Pg 5

Farooq Abdullah tells Pakistan to end cycle of violence in J&K



FILM: Pg 14

Kritika reveals she escaped the casting couch

— ‘BY GOD’S HELP, A FUTURE WITHOUT AMERICA’: MOJTABA KHAMENEI’S GULF RESOLVE —

Iran’s supreme leader vows to protect nuclear and missile capabilities amid a fragile ceasefire

Trump proposes plan to reopen Hormuz while maintaining Iran port blockade

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iran’s supreme leader said on Thursday that the Islamic Republic will protect its “nuclear and missile capabilities” as a national asset, likely seeking to draw a hard line as US President Donald Trump presses for a wider deal to cement the war’s shaky three-week ceasefire.

Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei maintained the defiant tone he has struck since taking over as supreme leader following the killing of his father in the war’s opening airstrikes.

In a written statement read by a state television anchor, Khamenei — who has not been seen in public since becoming supreme leader — said the only place Americans belonged in the Persian Gulf is “at the bottom of its waters” and that a “new chapter” was being written in the region’s history.

“Ninety million proud and honourable Iranians inside and outside the country regard all of Iran’s identity-based, spiritual,



human, scientific, industrial and technological capacities, from nanotechnology and biotechnology to nuclear and missile capabilities, as national assets and will protect them just as they protect the country’s waters, land and airspace,” Khamenei said.

His remarks come as Iran’s

oil industry is being squeezed by a US Navy blockade halting its oil tankers from getting out to sea. But the world economy is also under pressure as Iran maintains its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of all crude oil is transported.

On Thursday, the global

benchmark for oil, Brent crude, traded as high as \$126 a barrel. That shock to oil supplies and prices is putting pressure on Trump, who on Thursday floated a new plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Under the plan, the US would continue its blockade on Iranian ports, while coordinat-

ing with allies to impose higher costs on Iran’s attempts to subvert the free flow of energy, according to a senior administration official who spoke on condition of anonymity. The official added that it is just one of multiple diplomatic and policy efforts that Trump is weighing.

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HIGHLIGHTS

- » Khamenei claims a “new chapter” is unfolding in regional history
- » Iran calls technological sectors, including nuclear, core national identity assets
- » US Navy blockade squeezes Iran’s oil exports, limiting tanker movement
- » Iran maintains control over Strait of Hormuz, key global oil chokepoint
- » US aims to curb Iran’s oil revenue, forcing economic pressure
- » Iran delays nuclear talks; insists program is peaceful despite 60% enrichment

Brent crude surges over \$125 a barrel

HONG KONG: The price of Brent crude oil briefly surpassed USD 126 a barrel early Thursday as stalled US-Iran talks raised doubts over the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and a permanent end to the Iran war.

Brent crude to be delivered in June jumped 3.3 per cent to USD 121.90 after briefly soaring past USD 126 per barrel. Brent to be delivered in July rose 1.4 per cent to USD 112.02.

Benchmark US crude climbed 1.3 per cent to USD 108.28 per barrel.

Before the war began in late February, Brent crude was

Continued on P4

— MORE SHOWERS PREDICTED —

Rain, hailstorms sweep several states, bring relief from severe heat



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Unseasonal showers, thunderstorms and gusty winds swept across several parts of India on Thursday, offering relief from persistent heatwave conditions even as weather-related incidents caused damage and loss of life in some regions.

In the national capital, sudden rain accompanied by hailstorms brought down temperatures during the day. The India Meteorological Department issued an orange alert warning of intensified weather activity over the next few hours. Dark clouds covered large parts of Delhi-NCR as strong winds, at times reaching 70 kmph, were recorded alongside lightning and moderate rainfall.

The IMD said hailstorms and thunderstorms with light to moderate rain were likely in isolated pockets such as Dilshad Garden, Seemapuri, Shahdara and nearby areas. Other parts of the city including Civil Lines, India Gate, ITO and Lajpat Nagar were also expected to receive rainfall with lightning in the short term. The alert, which signals preparedness for severe weather, cautioned that gusty winds and lightning could disrupt traffic and outdoor movement.

Civic authorities moved in parallel to address seasonal challenges. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi issued an advisory directing departments to ensure access to drinking water and cooling

TAKEAWAYS

- » Hailstorms and winds up to 70 kmph swept parts of Delhi-NCR, disrupting traffic and outdoor activity
- » Bengaluru saw severe flooding, uprooted trees and traffic chaos after intense rainfall
- » Ten deaths reported in Bengaluru due to rain-related incidents, including seven in a hospital wall collapse
- » IMD forecast continued thunderstorms and heavy rain across West Bengal till May 4
- » Sub-Himalayan districts likely to see very heavy rainfall; south Bengal may face winds of 50–60 kmph

facilities in public spaces such as schools, dispensaries and community centres.

Further south, heavy rain and hailstorms lashed Bengaluru, triggering widespread disruption. Over the past 24 hours, ten people lost their lives in rain-related incidents. Seven of these deaths occurred when a wall collapsed at a hospital on Wednesday. Two people died due to electrocution, while another fatality was reported after a cement block pierced through a house roof during the storm.

The intense downpour, which lasted nearly an hour in several

Continued on P4

PMLA case: Delhi court grants bail to I-PAC director Vinesh Chandel

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: A Delhi court on Thursday granted regular bail to Vinesh Chandel, a director of political consultancy firm Indian Political Action Committee (I-PAC), in a money laundering case being probed by the Enforcement Directorate (ED).

The order was passed by Additional Sessions Judge Amit Bansal at the Patiala House Court. The court noted that the ED chose not to oppose the bail plea, a factor that weighed significantly in granting relief. It observed that since the prosecution did not contest the application despite being given the opportunity, the stringent “twin conditions” under Section 45 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) would not apply in this instance.

Chandel was arrested on April 13 in connection with the case,

Continued on P4

SC orders forensic test of audio clip linking ex-CM Biren Singh to Manipur violence

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday ordered the National Forensic Sciences University to examine a two-hour-36-minute audio clip allegedly linking former Manipur chief minister N Biren Singh to the 2023 ethnic violence. A bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and K Vinod Chandran acted after advocate Prashant Bhusan submitted the full recording. The court directed a comparison with admitted voice samples and asked for a report. Earlier, partial clips were found to have been tampered with. Over 260 people died and thousands were displaced in the Meitei-Kuki clashes.

See P6

ENERGY SECURITY IN FOCUS

PM to visit Netherlands, Sweden, Norway, Italy this month

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to undertake a four-nation visit to Europe from May 15 to 20, with officials indicating that energy security, trade continuity amid the West Asia crisis, and cooperation in emerging technologies will dominate discussions.

According to authoritative sources, the tour will cover Netherlands, Sweden, Norway, and Italy. There is also a possibility of a short stopover in the United Arab Emirates either at the start or conclusion of the visit, though no official announcement has been made so far.



In Norway, Modi is scheduled to participate in the third India-Nordic summit on May 15 and 16. The meeting was originally planned for May last year but was cancelled following the Pahal-gam terror attack. The summit is

CLOSER LOOK

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- » In Norway, Modi is scheduled to participate in the third India-Nordic summit on May 15 and 16

expected to address innovation, economic growth, climate-friendly initiatives, and expanding trade and investment ties. On the sidelines, Modi is likely to meet leaders from Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, and Sweden.

This will mark Modi’s first visit to Europe since India and the European Union concluded a long-pending free trade agreement in January after years of negotiations. While Denmark, Finland, and Sweden are EU members, Norway and Iceland are not part of the bloc.

Officials noted that discussions with European leaders will include maintaining stable energy supplies and addressing disruptions in trade routes linked to tensions in West Asia. “Ensuring uninterrupted energy flows and reducing vulnerabilities in trade will be central themes,” a source said.

In the Netherlands, talks are expected to

Continued on P4

— COUNTING OF VOTES ON MAY 4 WILL BEGIN AT 8 AM —

Bengal: EC signals possible reduction in counting centres, keeps repoll option open

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Election Commission on Thursday did not rule out the possibility of repoll in some booths in the state, stating that a full scrutiny report from the field level is still awaited, even as it indicated that the number of counting centres may be reduced.

Special Observer Subrata Gupta, under directions of the apex poll body, visited booths in Falta, Diamond Harbour

BENGAL POLLS

- » Scrutiny has been completed in Nadia, East Burdwan, Kolkata North and Kolkata South, and there will be no repoll there
- » The final report is awaited from South 24-Parganas, North 24-Parganas, Hooghly and Howrah. We expect that repoll, if any, will be held on May 2 or May 3
- » According to officials, the highest number of EVM-related complaints — 32 — came from Falta, followed by Diamond Harbour (29), Mograhat (13) and Budge Budge (3), all in South 24-Parganas

and other areas of South 24 Parganas to examine 77 complaints related to malfunction-

ing or alleged tampering of electronic voting machines (EVMs).

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— PUSHES FOR FASTER TRIALS IN RAPE CASES, SUGGESTS ONE-WEEK TIMELINE —

Minor’s pregnancy: SC urges Centre to remove 20-week limit for rape survivors

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday said a minor cannot be compelled to continue with an unwanted pregnancy, calling on the Centre to revisit the legal framework governing medical termination in cases of rape, including those involving children.

Hearing a curative plea linked to a 15-year-old survivor seeking to terminate a 30-week pregnancy, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi questioned the existing statutory limits and urged reforms. The court said



the law must reflect changing realities and should not impose rigid timelines where pregnancies result from sexual violence.

“Please amend your law that when there is pregnancy due to rape etc, then time limitation will not be there. The law needs

KEY POINTS

- » The case involves a 15-year-old survivor seeking termination of a 30-week pregnancy
- » The bench criticised All India Institute of Medical Sciences for challenging the earlier order allowing termination
- » AIIMS argued that the foetus is viable at 30 weeks and termination could risk severe

deformities and long-term harm to the minor mother

- » The court rejected framing the issue as “child versus foetus,” stressing the survivor’s autonomy and mental health
- » It said the final decision must rest with the minor and her parents, with AIIMS providing medical counselling, not deciding for them

proceedings, suggesting that trials in such sensitive cases should be concluded within a week to avoid compounding trauma.

The observations came after All India Institute of Medical Sciences sought to set aside an earlier order permitting the termination. The hospital had argued that the pregnancy had reached a stage where termination could result in the birth of a severely deformed child and pose long-term health risks to the minor mother.

Appearing for AIIMS, Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati told the court that the pregnancy

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GROUND TRUTH



Labourers carry bricks at a brick kiln, on the eve of Labour Day, also known as May Day, in Patna, Bihar, Thursday

PTI

MP: 4 dead, several missing as tourist boat overturns in Jabalpur reservoir



JABALPUR: Four persons died and 15 others were rescued after a river cruise boat carrying 29 passengers overturned in the Bargi dam reservoir after encountering a sudden storm on Thursday in Jabalpur district, an official said.

Ten tourists were still missing and an operation was on in full swing to trace and rescue them, he said.

A total of 29 tickets were issued for the cruise in the Bargi dam reservoir, and among them, four people drowned, while 15 were rescued, the official said.

The Bargi Dam has been constructed on the river Nar-mada in Jabalpur district.

A search and rescue operation for the missing passengers was continuing on a war footing. The Jabalpur collector and Superintendent of Police, along with SDRF (State Disaster Response Force) and other rescue teams, are present at the site, the official said.

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav said the local administration and rescue personnel were continuing their operation after the tragic cruise boat accident in the Bargi

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SECTOR 24 GOLF COURSE

Dwarka pond tragedy: 3 children drown; inquiry into safety lapses

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
& ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Three children aged between eight and ten years drowned in a pond at the Sector 24 Golf Course in Dwarka on Wednesday morning. The police were alerted about the incident through a PCR call received at the Sector 23 Dwarka Police Station.

According to the Delhi Police, a PCR call was received at Police Station Sector 23 Dwarka at approximately 7:07 AM on April 30, reporting that three children had drowned in the water body.

Acting immediately, the Station House Officer (SHO) along with police personnel rushed to the spot, while other emergency agencies, including the fire brigade, were alerted.



Upon arrival, authorities found the three children submerged in the pond. With assistance from fire brigade teams, all three were retrieved from the water.

However, they could not be revived. Officials noted that the

children's clothes were found outside the pond, leading to initial suspicions that they had entered the water to bathe and accidentally drowned.

The identities of the deceased children were yet to be confirmed at the time of

CLOSER LOOK

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Development Authority (DDA), which manages the golf course, expressed deep sorrow over the tragedy.

In response, the authority has constituted a three-member inquiry committee led by a senior official to investigate the matter. The committee has been directed to submit its findings within a week.

The incident has raised serious concerns about safety measures around open water bodies in public spaces, particularly in areas accessible to children. Officials indicated that responsibility will be fixed and appropriate action taken based on the findings of the inquiry.

Meanwhile, police have initiated further investigation into the case, examining all possible angles, including safety lapses and lack of preventive measures at the site.

Man falls from Dabri flyover after collision, dies; driver absconds

Victim is from Jharkhand's Godda

NEW DELHI A food delivery agent died after falling from the Dabri flyover in southwest Delhi when his scooter was allegedly hit by a car on Thursday morning, police said.

The car driver fled from the spot, police said.

A PCR call was received at 7:35 am informing that a person had fallen from the Dabri flyover on Pankha road and required immediate medical assistance, they said.

A police team rushed to the spot and found a damaged scooter and a car on the flyover. The scooter rider sustained serious injuries and was immediately shifted to a nearby hospital in an ambulance, where doctors declared him dead, they added. According to police, the victim was identified as Rajkumar, a resident of Jharkhand's Godda district. He was working as a delivery executive with a private food



delivery service in Delhi.

The car involved in the accident bears a Delhi registration number and is registered in the name of a Dabri resident, police said. "The body has been preserved in a mortuary and efforts are underway to apprehend the absconding driver," a senior police officer said.

A case has been registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and an investigation is underway to ascertain the exact sequence of events leading to the accident, police said.

News at a glance

MEWAT-BASED BURGLARY GANG KINGPIN HELD

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old proclaimed offender and alleged kingpin of a Mewat-based gang targeting mobile stores across Delhi-NCR has been arrested, police said on Thursday. The accused, Arman, a resident of Nuh in Haryana, had been absconding for over three years and was declared a proclaimed offender by the Patiala House Court in June 2025. He is accused of masterminding night-time break-ins at mobile showrooms, including a 2023 burglary in Delhi Cantonment. Arrested near Nuh court on April 29, Arman is a habitual offender with multiple cases.

MURDER SUSPECT NABBED AFTER BRIEF GUNFIRE

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old murder suspect, who allegedly used minors to carry out crimes, was arrested after a brief encounter in northwest Delhi's Ashok Vihar, police said. The accused, Suraj, opened fire at a police team near Prembari Pul; a bullet struck a constable's bulletproof jacket. Police retaliated, shooting him in the leg before arresting him. He is linked to a April 29 murder in Wazirpur, where a man was stabbed.

Former NSG commando fatally shot in 'revenge' killing in GGM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A former NSG commando out on parole was shot dead in Kanan village under the Manesar police station area on Thursday morning in an apparent revenge killing, police said.

The deceased, identified as Sundar Fauji (55), was released on parole last month in connection with the murder of a former sarpanch, Bahadur Chauhan, in 2018.

According to police, Fauji was out on a morning walk when the former sarpanch's son, Rohan, and his close aide waylaid him near a market around 8.30 am, pulled out their pistols and shot him dead.

Fauji was out on a morning walk when he was shot dead by the ex-sarpanch's son

Eyewitnesses said that around five rounds were fired, adding that the accused immediately fled the scene while brandishing their weapons.

After the incident, the police reached the spot and rushed Fauji to the hospital, where he was pronounced dead, police said.

A video of the killing has also surfaced. The entire incident occurred in just ten seconds, the police said.

A preliminary investigation

revealed that Rohan wanted to kill Fauji to avenge his father's killing, police added.

Fauji, a resident of Kanan village, IMT Manesar police station, was accused of murdering Chauhan, allegedly over a financial dispute.

"One of the accused has been identified as Rohan. He is the son of Bahadur, a former sarpanch, who was murdered by Fauji. He was in jail in connection with the case and was released on parole on March 29," Sunil Kumar, SHO of Manesar police station, said.

"Rohan and his accomplice murdered him on Thursday morning. Both the accused are absconding, and efforts are on to nab them," Kumar added.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Police have arrested five men for allegedly barging into a woman's house, claiming her husband sent them, confining her and then fleeing with cash and jewellery worth around Rs 45 lakh, an official said on Thursday.

The police identified the accused as Parthvi Singh (24), Laxminarayan Singh (29), Ranjit Singh (24), Ramkesh (23) and Ramkaran Singh (25), all residents of Rajasthan.

Police said one more accused, Surrender, is absconding. The incident took place on April 13 at Hargovind Enclave, where three of the accused entered the 35-year-old com-



plaint's house in south Delhi on a false pretext.

Police said the accused allegedly overpowered and gagged her, confined her in a bathroom, assaulted her and decamped with valuables.

The victim later managed to free herself, raised an alarm and was taken to the hospital for treatment.

During the investigation, police analysed technical input

A swift inter-state op was launched, and within 12 hours, three accused were apprehended

and, with help from local intelligence, identified one of the accused, Parthvi Singh, who was related to the complainant and had prior knowledge of the house. "A swift inter-state operation was launched, and within 12 hours, three accused were apprehended from agricultural fields in Bharatpur, Rajasthan," a senior officer said.

During interrogation, the accused revealed that they

divided the looted property at the Alwar bus stand and handed it over to their associates. Subsequently, police said Ramkaran was arrested from a forest area near Chamunda Mata Mandir, and part of the stolen property was recovered from Ramkesh.

Police also recovered the absconding accused's share from a forest and the dam area.

Officials said police recovered items, including gold bangles, chains, rings, earrings, silver anklets and jewellery.

Police said the accused had previously been involved in burglary and theft cases in Rajasthan. Further efforts are underway to apprehend the absconding accused.

Cross-border mobile theft network busted

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Crime Branch of the Delhi Police has busted an organised interstate racket with links to Nepal that trafficked stolen mobile phones, arresting two accused and recovering 40 devices connected to multiple theft cases across the capital.

Acting on a tip-off, officials launched a nearly two-month-long intelligence and surveillance operation to track the illegal movement of stolen phones from Delhi to Nepal. The breakthrough came when one of the accused, a Nepal-based receiver, was intercepted just minutes before he could flee with a fresh consignment.

Based on specific inputs, a raiding team laid a trap near Crown Plaza parking in east Delhi and apprehended Shah Nawaj, a resident of Nand Nagari, while he was delivering stolen phones. Six mobile phones were recovered from his possession. Simultaneously, Mohd Rizwan, originally from Kanpur in Uttar Pradesh, was arrested near Ghazipur while attempting to board a bus towards the Nepal border with a trolley bag containing 34 stolen devices.



Verification through the CEIR portal and ZIPNET confirmed that all 40 recovered phones were linked to theft or loss reports. The recoveries have led to the detection of six cases registered at police stations including Kashmiri Gate, Keshav Puram, Kamla Market, Paharganj, Kalindi Kunj and Kishangarh. Investigations revealed that Rizwan had built a well-organised network over the past decade, sourcing stolen phones from local thieves in Delhi at low prices and transporting them to Nepal for resale at significant profits.

He allegedly earned Rs 3,000 to Rs 4,000 per device and is believed to have trafficked thousands of phones, eventually setting up a shop in Nepal using the proceeds.

Police said Shah Nawaj is a habitual offender with prior involvement in seven cases, while Rizwan also has a criminal history in Uttar Pradesh.

Row at Jamia Millia Islamia over VC's 'Mahadev DNA' remark, SFI protests

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A controversy has emerged at Jamia Millia Islamia after the Students' Federation of India (SFI) unit on campus strongly criticised Vice Chancellor Mazhar Asif over a remark made during a recent programme.

In a statement, the Students' Federation of India (SFI) alleged that the Vice Chancellor's comment that "we all have Mahadev's DNA" was "unscientific" and inconsistent with the academic ethos of the university. The student body further claimed that the remark undermined the institution's commitment to scientific temper.



The controversy coincided with protests by students against the 'Yuva Kumbh' event reportedly organised at the Faculty of Engineering and Technology auditorium. According to SFI, the programme proceeded despite resistance from sections of students, leading to delays and heightened tensions on campus. Allegations of a crackdown

have also surfaced, with SFI claiming that protesting students were subjected to force by the proctorial team. It described the administrative response as excessive, alleging that demonstrators were manhandled during what it termed a peaceful protest.

The student organisation has demanded accountability from the university administration, accusing it of endorsing divisive rhetoric and curbing democratic expression. It further asserted that such developments raise broader concerns about the space for dissent within academic institutions.

University authorities have yet to issue a detailed response to the allegations.

Woman beaten to death by husband

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old woman was allegedly beaten to death by her husband following a domestic dispute in northeast Delhi's Sonia Vihar, police said on Thursday. The accused, who had fled after the incident, has since been apprehended.

The victim, identified as Poonam, was found uncon-

scious after a PCR call on Wednesday evening and taken to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital, where she was declared dead. Police said she had sustained severe head injuries. Preliminary investigation suggests her husband, Rupak, assaulted her during a quarrel. Sources alleged he repeatedly hit her and banged her head against a wall, causing fatal injuries.

CALLS FOR FASTER WORK, BETTER SEGREGATION Bhalswa landfill to be cleared by December '26, says Mayor

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Mayor of Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Pravesh Wahi, on Thursday inspected the Bhalswa landfill site and the compressed biogas (CBG) plant at Ghoga, reiterating the civic body's commitment to eliminating legacy waste and improving sanitation infrastructure in the capital.

During the visit, the Mayor reviewed ongoing biominer and bioremediation operations at the Bhalswa site and directed officials to accelerate the pace of work. He stated that the entire stock of legacy waste at the landfill would be cleared by December 2026, following which the reclaimed land would be levelled and utilised for public welfare initiatives, including the development of a green belt.

According to officials, the landfill once contained nearly 73 lakh metric tonnes of waste. Biominer operations, which



began in November 2022, have already processed a significant portion, reducing the height of the waste mound from 65 metres to around 30 metres. Approximately 13.58 lakh metric tonnes of waste remain to be cleared.

Sanjeev Khirwar, along with senior officials including Additional Commissioner Arun Kumar Mishra, Chief Engineer P.C. Meena, and Narela Zone Deputy Commis-

sioner Raghavendra Meena, accompanied the Mayor during the inspection.

At the Ghoga CBG plant, the Mayor emphasised the need for efficient operations and appealed to residents, RWAs, and market associations to adopt waste segregation at source. He added that RWAs achieving full compliance would be incentivised as part of the city's push towards a garbage-free Delhi.

Security guard found dead under suspicious circumstances

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 37-year-old security guard was found dead under suspicious circumstances at an under-construction hospital site in outer Delhi's Sultanpuri area, police said on Thursday.

The deceased, Sunil Kumar, a resident of Sultanpuri, was on night duty at the site near Jalebi Chowk.

He had reported for work around 8 pm on April 29 but did not return home, prompting his family to alert police the next morning.

During a search, his body was found in bushes within the site, which lacked electricity. He was taken to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital.

Police said no external injuries were found. The cause of death will be confirmed after post-mortem. All angles are being investigated.



A pipping ceremony at Police Headquarters honoured 182 retiring Delhi Police personnel with honorary rank promotions, marking the fifth event since the scheme's introduction in December



Delhi Police's week-long anti-drug campaign, "Nasha – Not Cool", concluded after extensive outreach across the capital, witnessing participation from students, residents and community groups

No vendor lock-in, schools must say it loud, says CM Rekha Gupta

CM, Minister flag off Somnath Yatra train with 1,400 devotees

The train, comprising 19 AC 3-tier coaches, will travel to Veraval in Gujarat, from where pilgrims will visit the Somnath Temple and other religious sites.

Delhi Assembly marks 108th anniv of 1918 War Conference

The helpline is part of a broader framework introduced under the Delhi Preservation of Trees Act, 1994. The new system includes real-time tracking of complaints, round-the-clock monitoring through control rooms, and enhanced powers for forest officials to intervene on the spot. Authorities can now stop violations, seize equipment, and coordinate with law enforcement agencies when required. Highlighting the importance of public participation, officials stressed that timely reporting is crucial for the system to function effectively.

Tree SOS: Dial to save Capital's green cover

City Briefs

April signs off with a COOL SURPRISE

Delhi records lowest monthly average AQI for April in 9 years

During the pre-monsoon season, rising temperatures combined with moisture lead to the rapid formation of towering clouds, triggering gusty winds, thunderstorms and spells of intense rainfall, Palawat said.



Ministry of Culture
Government of India



Archaeological
Survey of India



National Museum
New Delhi



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Prime Minister



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Hon'ble Union Minister of Home Affairs & Cooperation,
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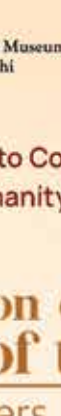
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LAST MILITANT GROUP LAYS DOWN ARMS

Mizoram declared ‘insurgency-free’

MPOST BUREAU

AIZAWL: The last remaining ethnic insurgent group of Mizoram laid down arms on Thursday, and the state became “insurgency-free”, Chief Minister Lalduhoma said.

Although it remained dormant for several years, a faction of the Hmar People’s Convention (Democratic) or HPC(D), headed by Lalhmingthanga Sanate, indulged in sporadic criminal activities at irregular intervals, officials said. The Sanate faction was considered the last surviving insurgent group in the northeastern state.

The HPC(D) had been demanding an autonomous district council for the Hmar community people under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution.

A total of 43 cadres of the group, including Sanate, surrendered their weapons to the government during a “homecoming and arms laying ceremony” at Sesawng near Aizawl during the day.

The ‘homecoming ceremony’ follows the peace accord signed between the Mizoram government and the HPC(D) on April 14, effectively marking the

end of insurgency in the state.

Speaking at the event, Lalduhoma said that the shadow of HPC(D) insurgency remained in mind whenever peace was spoken of in Mizoram in the past.

“We approached negotiations with an open heart to reach an agreement. Our home minister and his colleagues worked tirelessly. Today, we have reached our goal. Now, with a peaceful heart, we can proudly say Mizoram is a truly peaceful state,” the Chief Minister said.

Urging various Mizo tribes to reunite, Lalduhoma emphasised that no single tribe stands above the identity of being Mizo.

“We are all Mizos. If subtribes within the Mizo community try to stand entirely on their own today, it is unlikely they would succeed. We must find contentment in our shared Mizo identity. We will thrive only through unity,” he said.

Stating that the price of peace is high, Lalduhoma, who resigned from the Indian Police Service (IPS) decades ago to mediate peace during the secessionist movement spearheaded by the Mizo National Front (MNF), recalled that he

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Although it remained dormant for several years, a faction of the Hmar People’s Convention (Democratic) or HPC(D), headed by Lalhmingthanga Sanate, indulged in sporadic criminal activities at irregular intervals’
- » The Sanate faction was considered the last surviving insurgent group in the northeastern state

- » The HPC(D) had been demanding an autonomous district council for the Hmar community people under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution
- » A total of 43 cadres of the group, including Sanate, surrendered their weapons to the government during a “homecoming and arms laying ceremony” at Sesawng near Aizawl

left behind and lost many things so that peace could prevail in the region. He lauded the surrendering cadres for their bravery, asserting that only the truly courageous have the strength to lay down arms for the greater good of the community.

Lalduhoma reaffirmed that Mizoram no longer tolerates insurgency and called for collective commitment to safeguarding peace.

“The Mizo people will no longer permit insurgency to resurface in our land. Let us

all abstain from anything that could trigger discord and unrest. Let us abandon policies and ideologies that incite conflict just for the sake of temporary gains and work together to sustain lasting peace and stability in our state,” he said.

Home Minister K Sapdanga described the day as “historic,” attributing the success of the agreement to Lalduhoma’s consistent commitment to peace and hailed him as a “Symbol of Peace”.

The home minister also said

that the government will work hand-in-hand with the surrendered cadres to fulfil their aspirations through democratic and administrative means.

Assembly speaker Lalbiakzama, who was elected from Hmar-majority Chalfihli constituency, welcomed the development, noting that peace in Hmar-inhabited areas had long been a key priority.

Speaking on behalf of the group, Sanate acknowledged the changing political climate under the current Lalduhoma’s administration.

He stated that the construction of the “Unity Bridge” over Tuivai River linking Tipaimuk area in Manipur and the Tuirial-Mauchar road connecting Assam, as tangible signs that the government is committed to the development of Hmar-majority areas. Officials said that the Hmar People’s Convention (HPC) spearheaded a political movement since 1986, demanding the creation of an autonomous district council (ADC) under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution for Hmar-populated areas in northern and northeastern Mizoram.

Although initially function-

ing as a political platform, the HPC turned to armed insurgency in May 1987 when its leaders felt their peaceful protests yielded little or no results.

After seven years of insurgency, the HPC, then headed by Hmingchungnunga, signed a peace accord with the Mizoram government on 27 July 1994, leading to the establishment of Sinlung Hills Development Council (SHDC), officials said.

However, dissatisfied with the terms of the agreement, those HPC members who did not come overground in 1994, formed HPC(D) under the leadership of Sanate to resume the demand for ADC in Mizoram.

In 2011, the HPC(D) was split into two groups, one headed by H Zosangbera and the other by Sanate.

The Zosangbera-led faction signed a peace accord with the state government in April 2018, resulting in the creation of the Sinlung Hills Council (SHC), which replaced the SHDC with enhanced autonomy.

Sanate, who hailed from Khawlian village in Mizoram’s Saitual district bordering Manipur, then remained outside the peace process.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Kerala: POCSO case registered against 4

Including VHP leader, film director

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

KOCHI: An FIR under the POCSO Act has been lodged against four persons, among them a VHP leader and a film director, on a complaint by a girl who came into the lime-light during the Prayagraj Kumbh Mela and later married her friend, a Muslim man, at a temple in Kerala, police said on Thursday.

A senior police officer said VHP leader and advocate Anil Vilayil and film director Sanoj Mishra are among the four accused in the case.

The FIR was registered on Wednesday following a complaint by the girl, who has accused the director of misbehaving with her while she was shooting for his film, ‘The Diary of Manipur’.

Police officials at Ernakulam Central Police Station said the allegation against Vilayil is that he defamed the complainant on social media platforms.

The complainant also appeared before a magistrate, who recorded her confidential statement on Thursday evening, police said.

Officials said the case would be transferred to Madhya Pradesh Police as the alleged incident occurred in that state.

Police said the case is also linked to a dispute over the marriage, after the girl’s parents claimed she was 16 years old and lodged a complaint against her husband, Farman, at Maheshwar police station in Madhya Pradesh.

The girl, however, has maintained that she is 18 years old.

A team of Madhya Pradesh Police recently visited Kerala to investigate the matter. The Kerala High Court on April 8 granted Farman interim protection from arrest till May 20.

The girl had earlier this month submitted a petition to the state police chief and the Kochi city police commissioner seeking protection, alleging attempts to forcibly take her to Madhya Pradesh.

CPI(M) leaders, including state secretary M V Govindan, Minister V Sivankutty, and Rajya Sabha MP A A Rahim, attended the wedding held at a temple in Thiruvananthapuram last month.

From Page 1

Iran’s supreme

With a fragile ceasefire in place, the US and Iran are locked in a standoff over the Strait. The US blockade is designed to prevent Iran from selling its oil, depriving it of crucial revenue while also potentially creating a situation where Tehran has to shut off production because it has nowhere to store oil.

The Strait’s closure is also a problem for the US’ Gulf allies, which use the waterway to export their oil and gas.

A recent Iranian proposal would push negotiations on the country’s nuclear programme to a later date. Trump said one of the major reasons he went to war was to deny Iran the ability to develop nuclear weapons. Iran has long maintained its programme is peaceful, though it enriched uranium at near-weapons-grade levels of 60 per cent.

Pakistan on Thursday said it was still facilitating indirect talks between the US and Iran aimed at easing tensions, but Islamabad would also welcome direct communication between the two sides, even by phone.

“If the two parties can engage in real-time conversations, that could ease the sticking points,” said Ministry of Foreign Affairs spokesperson Tahir Andrabi at a weekly news briefing.

According to a report by Reuters news agency, Iran said on Thursday it would respond with “long and painful strikes” on US positions if Washington renewed attacks, and also reasserted its control over the Strait of Hormuz, complicating US plans for a coalition to reopen the waterway.

Iran has threatened to use a new weapon in the war against the US and Israeli forces, one of which the enemy forces are “deeply afraid of” and could give them a “heart attack”.

Iran’s Navy Commander Rear Admiral Shahram Irani said the Islamic Republic will “very soon” confront the enemy forces with a weapon “it is deeply afraid of”, according to state-run Press TV.

“And it is right next to them [too]... I hope they won’t have a heart attack,” he noted in reference to the weapon in question.

He also mocked the Trump administration’s strategy to force Tehran to the negotiating table using economic pressure by blocking the Iranian oil trade through Hormuz, saying “enemies” have wrongfully thought they would achieve the results they had sought through their latest bout of unprovoked aggression against Iran “in the shortest possible time.”

“That very assumption has now turned into a joke in military academies.”

Irani also claimed that the Iranian forces have carried out at least “seven missile opera-

tions” against the US aircraft carrier Abraham Lincoln, which, according to him, prevented the “United States from being able to launch aircraft or conduct air operations from the carrier for a period of time”.

Meanwhile, President Trump is slated to receive a briefing on Thursday on plans for a series of fresh military strikes on Iran to compel it to negotiate an end to the conflict, a US official told Reuters.

Any US attack on Iran, even if limited, will usher in “long and painful strikes” on US regional positions, a senior Revolutionary Guards official said.

“We’ve seen what happened to your regional bases, we will see the same thing happen to your warships,” Aerospace Force Commander Majid Mousavi was quoted by Iranian media as saying.

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres warned that if the disruption caused by the closure dragged on through mid-year, global growth would fall, inflation would rise and tens of millions more people would be pushed into poverty and extreme hunger.

“The longer this vital artery is choked, the harder it will be to reverse the damage,” he told reporters in New York.

Brent crude

trading around USD 70 per barrel.

There’s no clear path to an end to the war. The US has continued its blockade of Iranian ports while the Strait of Hormuz is closed, pushing oil prices higher.

Reports Thursday suggesting a possible escalation by US President Donald Trump doused hopes for a quick end to the conflict.

“The breakdown of talks between the US and Iran, along with President Trump reportedly rejecting Iran’s proposal for a reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, has the market losing hope for any quick resumption in oil flows,” ING Bank strategists Warren Patterson and Ewa Manthey wrote in a research note.

Oil prices vary depending on the type of crude oil, where it is being traded and under what terms, for futures contracts. By some measures, Brent has hit its highest level since its peak of USD 147.50 per barrel in 2008 during the global financial crisis.

With the war rattling world markets, the US dollar fell to 160.02 Japanese yen after surging earlier Thursday to its highest level in nearly two years. It closed at 160.44 yen on Wednesday.

The dollar has gained against other major currencies partly due to its status as a safe haven for investors in times of risk, and partly because US interest rates have remained relatively high as the Federal Reserve strives to balance a need to boost the economy with curbing the higher prices that partly are a result of the war.

The Fed’s decision to keep interest rates steady at its policymaking meeting Wednesday

further supported the dollar. Analysts said Japanese officials will likely intervene if the yen drops much more.

The euro rose to USD 1.1686 from USD 1.1675.

US futures retreated and world shares were mixed following a muted performance on Wall Street on Wednesday.

AGENCIES

Rain, hailstorms

areas, uprooted trees and electricity poles, crushed parked vehicles and flooded low-lying neighbourhoods. Major roads became impassable during peak hours, throwing traffic out of gear across the city.

Eastern India also witnessed a shift in weather patterns. Several parts of West Bengal received moderate to heavy rainfall accompanied by gusty winds on Wednesday evening, leading to a noticeable drop in night temperatures. According to the IMD, Amta in Howrah district recorded the highest rainfall in the 24-hour period ending Thursday morning at 97 mm.

The weather office has forecast continued activity in the state till May 4. Heavy to very heavy rainfall is expected in sub-Himalayan districts including Darjeeling, Jalpaiguri, Alipurdwar and Cooch Behar, with Kalimpong also likely to receive heavy rain till May 3. Thunderstorms with lightning and wind speeds of 50 to 60 kmph are anticipated across districts such as North and South 24 Parganas, Paschim Medinipur, Bankura and Nadia.

Meteorologists attributed the conditions to favourable wind patterns and strong moisture inflow from the Bay of Bengal, which are supporting widespread thunderstorm development across the region.

In the northern hills, parts of Himachal Pradesh experienced light to moderate rainfall over the past 24 hours. The Shimla Meteorological Centre reported intermittent showers in the state capital, where dense cloud cover reduced visibility significantly. Thunderstorms and lightning were also recorded in areas such as Kangra and Sundernagar.

The IMD has projected a wet spell in the state until May 6 due to an approaching western disturbance expected to influence the western Himalayan region from May 2. A yellow warning has been issued for thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds of 40 to 50 kmph in most districts on Sunday, extending to Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi and Shimla on Monday.

In Una district, rising temperatures prompted authorities to temporarily revise school timings to safeguard students from heat exposure.

Rajasthan has also seen slight moderation in temperatures in recent days due to dust storms and light rainfall, with maximum temperatures hovering between 40 and 42 degrees Celsius. The IMD indicated that another western disturbance,

combined with easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal, is likely to affect the state over the next four to five days, bringing thunderstorms, gusty winds and light to moderate rain in some areas.

Kerala, which has been grappling with intense heat, received heavy rainfall in several districts, bringing respite to residents. The IMD issued an orange alert for Kolam, Pathanamthitta, Alappuzha, Kottayam, Idukki and Ernakulam districts for a three-hour window starting at 4 pm. Such an alert indicates the likelihood of very heavy rainfall ranging from 11 cm to 20 cm.

The department also warned of thunderstorms accompanied by winds of up to 50 kmph in parts of these districts. Earlier forecasts had indicated the possibility of rain, lightning and winds of 40 to 50 kmph across Kerala between April 29 and May 3.

Along the southeastern coast, the IMD flagged continued discomfort due to a combination of high temperature and humidity across Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal. Temperatures in parts of Tamil Nadu are expected to remain about two degrees Celsius above normal. Despite the heat, light to moderate rainfall and thunderstorms are likely in some areas.

Heavy rain is forecast at isolated locations in districts such as the Nilgiris, Coimbatore, Erode, Tiruppur, Dindigul and Theni on Friday.

The widespread weather activity across regions reflects a transitional phase marked by interactions between western disturbances and moisture-laden winds from the Bay of Bengal. While the rainfall has provided relief from extreme heat in many areas, authorities continue to monitor conditions closely amid warnings of thunderstorms, lightning and strong winds that could affect daily life.

PM to Visit Netherlands

focus on expanding collaboration in semiconductors, artificial intelligence, green hydrogen, trade, and defence. Sweden’s agenda will centre on innovation-driven partnerships for sustainability.

The Italy leg of the tour is likely to advance cooperation in trade, investment, and defence. Italian Defence Minister Guido Crosetto is currently in New Delhi, aiming to establish a defence industrial framework that includes joint production of military equipment between the two countries.

PMLA case:

which originates from an FIR registered by Delhi Police. According to the ED, he is among the founders of PAC Consulting Private Limited and holds a 33 per cent stake in the firm.

The agency has alleged that its investigation has uncovered a series of financial irregularities linked to the company. These include the handling of both accounted and unaccounted funds, unsecured loans without clear business justification, and the generation of allegedly fake invoices. Funds were also purportedly routed through third-party entities to obscure their origin.

Investigators further claim that domestic and international hawala channels were used to transfer money. The ED has estimated that proceeds of crime amounting to around Rs 50 crore have been identified so far.

The case had earlier drawn attention after ED searches at I-PAC’s Salt Lake office in Kolkata triggered a political confrontation involving West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

Bengal: EC signals

“Scrutiny has been completed in Nadia, East Burdwan, Kolkata North and Kolkata South, and there will be no repoll there. The final report is awaited from South 24-Parganas, North 24-Parganas, Hooghly and Howrah. We expect that repoll, if any, will be held on May 2 or May 3. The Election Commission of India will take the final call, and we will inform people at least a day in advance so that they can cast their franchise,” said state Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Agarwal.

He added that the poll body is adopting a zero-tolerance approach and that repoll will be ordered wherever confirmed instances of EVM tampering or manipulation are found to have vitiated the poll.

According to officials, the highest number of EVM-related complaints — 32 — came from Falta, followed by Diamond Harbour (29), Mograhat (13) and Budge Budge (3), all in South 24-Parganas.

The poll body, which currently has 77 counting centres, indicated that the number may be reduced. “As per rules, there should be at least one counting centre in each district headquarters. However, we also have centres at the subdivision level. If large venues such as Netaji Indoor Stadium in Kolkata are used, the number of centres may be reduced further. We are assessing the situation in consultation with district electoral officers,” the CEO said.

In the 2016 Assembly elections, counting was conducted across 90 centres, which increased to 108 in 2021.

To prevent unauthorised entry into counting centres, the Election Commission has introduced a QR code-based photo identity card module on ECI-NET. The cards will be issued to authorised personnel, including returning officers, assistant returning officers, counting staff, technical personnel, candidates, election agents and counting agents.

A three-tier security mechanism has been prescribed for identity verification. At the first and second levels, photo identity cards issued by the returning officer will be checked manually. At the third and innermost cordon near the counting hall, entry will be allowed only after successful QR code verification.

Counting of votes on May 4 will begin at 8 am.

Minor’s pregnancy

had crossed 30 weeks and described it as “a viable life.” She also submitted that termination could lead to irreversible health complications for the minor and suggested the possibility of placing the child for adoption.

The bench, however, rejected the notion that the decision should be framed as “child versus foetus.” It maintained that the focus must remain on the survivor’s rights, particularly her mental and physical well-being. “Unwanted pregnancy cannot be thrust on a person. Imagine... she is a child. She should be studying now. But we want to make her a mother,” the court remarked, highlighting the emotional and social burden on the minor.

Justice Bagchi questioned the role of state institutions in making such decisions, stating that authorities must respect the agency of citizens. He said AIIMS could provide medical guidance but could not substitute its judgment for that of the survivor and her family. “Give respect to your citizen. Show data to the parents and if they choose to keep it, then so be it. But if they think the mental health is in jeopardy then they will take a call,” he said.

The court directed AIIMS to provide counselling to the minor and her parents, stressing that the final decision must rest with them. It also advised the involvement of psychiatrists and counsellors to ensure that the family makes an informed choice without coercion.

Referring to broader societal concerns, the bench noted that there are already many abandoned children and systemic challenges around adoption. It said forcing a 15-year-old to carry an unwanted pregnancy would add to her suffering and lifelong trauma.

The case builds on an earlier ruling delivered on April 24 by a separate bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan, which permitted the termination. The court had then noted that the minor had attempted to end her life twice and concluded that continuing the pregnancy was not in her best interest.

That bench also dismissed a review plea filed by AIIMS, stating that termination cannot be denied solely due to the advanced stage of pregnancy or the condition of the foetus. Denial on such grounds, it held, would undermine the right to bodily autonomy.

The Centre has also filed a curative petition, the final legal

avenue for reconsideration. Meanwhile, the court has reiterated that all medical safeguards must be ensured during the procedure and directed that it be carried out at the earliest, subject to the informed consent of the minor and her guardian.

The proceedings have brought renewed attention to reproductive rights, particularly in cases involving minors and survivors of sexual violence, and have prompted calls for legislative changes to align with constitutional protections.

MP: 4 dead

dam due to a severe storm. Public Works Minister Rakesh Singh, Tourism Minister Dharmendra Singh Lodhi, senior divisional, police officials and local people’s representatives have been directed to reach the scene of the tragedy to oversee the rescue operation, the CM said in a post on ‘X’.

Through a swift operation, 15 citizens were rescued and efforts were underway to locate those who are still missing, said Yadav.

“In this hour of crisis, the state government stands with the affected families with full sensitivity and is ensuring all possible assistance,” he maintained.

PWD minister Rakesh Singh, who reached the spot soon after arriving here from Delhi, termed the incident as most unfortunate. He said the CM has announced compensation of Rs 4 lakh each for the kin of the deceased.

“The incident took place around 6-6:15 pm. There were 29 passengers as well as two crew members. Fifteen passengers were rescued, while four others died. The boat has been set right. After completion of the search and rescue operation, a thorough probe would be initiated into the incident,” Singh said.

The priority is to search for those missing, with the operation getting difficult due to darkness setting in, he added.

As per eyewitnesses, strong winds turned the water choppy, leading to many onboard raising an alarm and asking the crew to take the boat back to the banks.

However, the crew was unable to hear these shouts and the boat drifted further and then overturned, they added.

Some locals rescued a few passengers wearing life jackets with the help of a rope, they said.

The news of the cruise boat accident in the Bargi dam is extremely sad and heart-breaking, said Congress MLA and Leader of Opposition in Assembly Umang Singhar.

“Humble tributes to all citizens who lost their lives in this accident, and deepest condolences to the bereaved families,” he said.

The Congress leader demanded that the state government immediately provide adequate compensation and all possible assistance to the families of the deceased.

AGENCIES



KERALA ASSEMBLY POLLS

UDF welcomes exit polls; LDF and BJP disagree with predictions

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THIRUVANANTHA-PURAM: The ruling LDF in Kerala on Thursday said that the exit polls did not show an anti-incumbency feeling among the people, while the Opposition UDF welcomed the predictions, saying they were similar to the outcome expected by the Congress-led front.

A day after the exit polls predicted a UDF win in the Assembly elections held in the state on April 9, the BJP-led NDA claimed that there was a strong anti-incumbency feeling among the people, but no pro-UDF wave in the state.

Both the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and the CPI(M)-headed Left Democratic Front (LDF), however, did not agree with the exit poll figures.

The LDF claimed it would return to power for a third

Highlights

- » The LDF claimed it would return to power for a third time
- » NDA claims that it would gain more seats than

what was predicted in the exit polls

- » 'We expect UDF to get more seats than what was predicted in the exit poll'

time, while the NDA claimed it would gain more seats than what was predicted in the exit polls.

On the other hand, the Congress-led UDF welcomed the exit polls, saying that it was similar to the outcome predicted by it.

At the same time, it said that it does not completely rely on the exit poll results.

Congress General Secretary (organisation), K C Venugopal, told reporters that although the exit polls did not indicate any anti-incumbency sentiment or a pro-UDF wave among voters, the party had sensed it during

the election campaign

"Anyways, there is no need to be concerned about it now. Everything will be clear on May 4. It will be UDF's day. We are not going by exit polls. Election results do not always match exit poll predictions," he said.

Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) chief Sunny Joseph and senior party leader K Muralaeddharan said the exit poll figures were close to the numbers calculated by the party and indicated that the UDF will come to power after the Assembly poll results are declared on May 4.

"So, as far as UDF is con-

cerned, our win is assured," Muralaeddharan told reporters and added that the chief minister will be decided after May 4.

"We expect the people's verdict to be in favour of the UDF," Joseph said at a press conference.

Congress-ally and a key UDF constituent, the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), also welcomed the exit polls, saying that it was similar to the outcome predicted by the front.

IUML supremo Sadik Ali Shihab Thangal told the media that since all the agencies that carried out the exit polls predicted a UDF win, it can be believed.

"We expect UDF to get more seats than what was predicted in the exit poll," he said.

Similar to the UDF, the LDF too expressed confidence of winning the Assembly polls and termed the exit poll figures as inconsequential.

At the same time, the Left Front claimed that the exit poll did not show any anti-incumbency factor.

CPI(M) state secretary M V Govindan, LDF convener T P Ramakrishnan, state Tourism Minister P A Mohamed Riyas and senior party leader N N Krishnadas were of the view that the exit polls were not important.

Govindan said the LDF was not worried, as the exit polls actually show that the Left Front will again come to power.

He also questioned the basis for the predictions that the BJP might win 3-14 seats and asserted that the saffron party will not win even one.

Ramakrishnan, Riyas and Krishnadas also spoke along similar lines.

Krishnadas and Riyas said that exit polls predicted that the LDF would lose in 2021, but they were proved wrong.

'Govt wants to delay caste census'

Govt had announced that caste enumeration of entire population will be included in upcoming Census: Cong

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Attacking the government over the caste census issue, the Congress on Thursday said it is yet to come out with any details of how this enumeration will be done and alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has every intention of delaying the exercise.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said today exactly a year ago, the Modi government had announced that caste enumeration of the entire population will be included in the upcoming Census.

"The recent chronology relating to this dramatic U-turn by the Prime Minister is this: On July 21 2021, the Home minister had answered a question in the Lok Sabha asked by a BJP MP Smt Raksha Nikhil Khadse (now a Minister herself) and said that the Government of India had decided as a matter of policy not to enumerate caste-wise popula-

Takeaways

- » The PM owes the leadership of the Congress an apology for his accusation, said Ramesh
- » 'A full year has passed. The details of how this caste enumeration will be done are still awaited'

tion," Ramesh said on X.

On September 21 2021, the Modi government filed an affidavit in the Supreme Court stating that any directive by the court to enumerate caste-wise population would be tantamount to interfering with a policy decision already taken by the Modi government, he said.

On April 16, 2023, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge wrote to the PM demanding an up-to-date caste census as part of the regular census, Ramesh pointed out.

"On April 28 2024, in a television interview to News18 Network, the prime minister attacked the Congress saying that its demand for a caste census was indicative of 'urban naxal' thought," he said.

The prime minister owes the leadership of the Congress an apology for his accusation, Ramesh said, adding that more importantly, he owes the people of India an explanation of why he allowed his mind to be contaminated by "urban naxal" thought when he announced a caste census on April 30, 2025.

"A full year has passed. The details of how this caste enumeration will be done are still awaited. There has been no dialogue with Opposition parties and state governments, let alone with experts in this subject," Ramesh said.

"The President of the Indian National Congress had written to the PM again on May 5, 2025 on the issue of the caste census. That letter was not even acknowledged. The issues raised in that letter remain very valid even now," he said.

Akhilesh Yadav attacks BJP over women's reservation, law & order in UP

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief and former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday accused the BJP of misleading the public on the issue of women's reservation and said the law has already been passed in Parliament in 2023.

Speaking to reporters while returning from a one-day visit to Hardoi, Yadav said all political parties had supported the women's reservation Bill when it was passed and alleged that the BJP was now indulging in false propaganda.

He said the public and women voters understand the reality and predicted that the BJP would be voted out in the 2027 elections.

Yadav alleged that crimes against women have increased since the BJP came to power and claimed that Uttar Pradesh accounts for the highest number of such incidents in the country.

He accused the government of using the police for political purposes and said victims are not getting justice even after approaching senior officers.

Referring to recent incidents, he cited cases from Hardoi, Ghazipur and Pratapgarh, alleging that victims did not receive justice despite repeated complaints. He claimed that the government was unwilling to acknowledge serious charges in some cases and said the situation persists because the Chief Minister is not taking action.

Targeting the BJP leadership, Yadav said the conduct of party leaders reflects an anti-women mindset and referred to remarks made by a BJP functionary in Mahoba.

Farooq Abdullah tells Pakistan to end cycle of violence in J&K

SRINAGAR: Asserting that "enough is enough", National Conference president Farooq Abdullah says Pakistan should "call it a day" and end the cycle of violence in Jammu and Kashmir.

While terrorism has largely subsided, Pakistan's refusal to accept Jammu and Kashmir as an integral part of India continues to fuel violence in the region, the three-time Jammu and Kashmir chief minister said.

"My humble advice to both these nations, my own nation and Pakistan, is that the time has come. Let us leave the path of violence and start finding ways of peace so that we can live with honour and dignity," the 88-year-old told news agency.

Discussing the Pahalgam terror attack, in which 26 people were killed, he said it was a "big blow" to efforts of rekindling brotherhood in



JKNC chief Farooq Abdullah during an interview, in Srinagar, Thursday PTI

they came out voluntarily and said this is not us we're not part of it," Abdullah said, recalling the scenes of protest after the attack last April.

The people of Jammu and Kashmir, especially those from the Valley, had sent a stern message to Pakistan that violence must end, he added.

"I hope our neighbour realised we will never favour terrorism and we will never be part of any such war in the future. This is not us. We are not animals. We are peace loving people and we want peace to prevail. Enough is enough... call it a day," he added.

In his view, the greatest threat facing the youth in Jammu and Kashmir today is no longer militancy but a rampant drug epidemic "eating the vitals" of not only the union territory but the nation.

Chhattisgarh CM moves resolution in Assembly for 33% women's quota in legislative bodies

RAIPUR: Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Thursday tabled a resolution in the state Assembly seeking the immediate implementation of one-third reservation for women in Parliament and all state legislative Assemblies after completing the delimitation process.

A one-day special session of the Assembly was convened to deliberate on the resolution, after the Constitution Amendment Bill to implement 33 per cent reservation for women was defeated in the Lok Sabha.

The Constitution Amendment Bill to implement reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and increase the number of Lok Sabha seats was defeated

Closer Look

- » A one-day special session of the Assembly was convened to deliberate on the

resolution

- » Speaker Raman Singh allotted four hours for discussion on the resolution

ted four hours for discussion on the resolution.

However, Leader of Opposition Charan Das Mahant said he has also submitted a similar resolution, appealing to the Centre to provide 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and Assemblies within the existing strength at the earliest, but it was not taken up.

The Speaker then said Mahant's proposal was a non-official resolution and could not be admitted because the special session's agenda had been pre-decided. He said that the session was convened for official business and disallowed the Opposition's resolution.

Shah in Ladakh to attend first-ever exposition of Buddha relics in India

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LEH: Union Home minister Amit Shah arrived in Ladakh on Thursday to attend the first-ever international exposition of holy relics of Lord Buddha in India, officials said.

Shah was received by Ladakh Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena and accorded a ceremonial welcome at the Kushok Bakula Rimpochee Airport here. Senior officials of the police and civil administration were also present.

During his two-day visit, Shah will pay respect to the sacred relics of Lord Buddha on the Buddha Purnima, which falls on Friday.

He will also lay foundation



Union Home minister Amit Shah being received at the airport for a two-day visit, in Leh PTI

be attending on the occasion of Buddha Purnima, the first ever international exposition of the holy relics of Lord Buddha, commencing on the 1st of May," he said.

"In this exposition, devotees from different parts of the world will offer veneration to the relics of Lord Buddha," he added.

The sacred Piprahwa relics of Buddha were brought to Leh in a special Indian Air Force aircraft on Wednesday by Drukpa Thuksey Rinpoche and Khenpo Thinlas Chosol of Matho Monastery.

The sacred relics were accorded a ceremonial reception on arrival, with people pouring out of their homes and gathering along the roads to pay respect.

ISI plot suspected ahead of Uttar Pradesh elections

Intelligence flags possible terror threat

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Intelligence inputs have flagged a possible terror threat ahead of the upcoming Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, with officials indicating that Pakistan's spy agency Inter-Services Intelligence may be attempting to orchestrate a major attack.

According to senior intelligence officials, the alleged plan involves a multi-layered strategy aimed at both executing an attack and diverting the attention of Indian security agencies. Sources said a coordinated propaganda campaign is being pushed to create confusion and keep investigative agencies engaged elsewhere.

Officials indicated that heightened suspicious activity has been observed in recent weeks, including attempts to gather information on sensitive locations. Intelligence inputs

Key Points

- » Officials indicated that heightened suspicious activity has been observed in recent weeks
- » Agencies have also flagged concerns over attempts to disturb communal harmony

suggest that operatives linked to the ISI may be involved in installing surveillance equipment such as CCTV cameras at key sites to monitor movement and map potential targets.

An officer familiar with the developments said the timing is significant as the state heads into a high-stakes election cycle next year. "Large public events and political gatherings increase vulnerability, making such periods attractive for hostile elements,"

the officer said. In a related development, violence in Noida has come under scrutiny, with police claiming that industrial workers were instigated to take to the streets through messages circulated on WhatsApp.

According to officials, the mobilisation appeared coordinated and raised concerns about external influence. Laxmi Singh said the possibility of a Pakistan-linked angle is also being examined, adding that agencies are probing whether the unrest was part of a broader attempt to create disruption.

Agencies have also flagged concerns over attempts to disturb communal harmony. Intercepts indicate that propaganda channels may be activated to incite tensions in different regions, including smaller towns and rural pockets, in an effort to create multiple pressure points for law enforcement.

No change of Karnataka CM 'for now', says Kharge

KALABURGAI: AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday said there was no Chief Minister change in Karnataka "for now" and that the leadership issue in the state will be resolved soon.

The Congress chief's statement comes amid speculations within the party and political circles about a possible decision on leadership change and cabinet reshuffle after May 4, once the results for Assembly elections in four states and one union territory, along with bypolls to two Assembly segments in Karnataka, are announced.

Supporters of Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar have been insisting on his elevation in lines with a rumoured power-sharing agreement with CM Siddaramaiah when the party won the 2023 Assembly polls.



DIP/Shabdarth/Display/14/26-27

BENCH DIRECTED NFSU TO ANALYSE RECORDING AND COMPARE VOICE

Manipur violence: SC orders fresh forensic probe in Biren Singh audio

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday directed for an examination of an audio clip allegedly linking former Manipur chief minister N Biren Singh to the ethnic violence in the northeastern state by the National Forensic Sciences University in Gujarat.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and K Vinod Chandran issued the direction after advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner, “Kuki Organisation for Human Rights Trust; an NGO, argued that they were placing on record the complete audio clip, which was more than two hours long.

The bench directed the National Forensic Sciences University (NFSU) to analyse the recording and compare the voice sample in it with the admitted voice samples of Singh.

It said, “Prashant Bhushan, counsel for the petitioner,



N Biren Singh

states that the full audio clip of two hours and 36 minutes has been copied onto a pen drive from the original device. The said pen drive, being the first copy of the original, shall be furnished to the other side, to be forwarded to the NFSU for comparison with the admitted voice recordings of the individual concerned.”

On January 7, the top court ordered a forensic examination of a 48-minute audio recording, which, the NGO alleged, pointed to the role of Singh in the 2023 ethnic violence in

Key Points

» On January 7, the top court ordered a forensic examination of a 48-minute audio recording, which, the NGO alleged, pointed to the role of Singh in the

2023 ethnic violence in Manipur

» On December 15 last year, the bench questioned why the entire available leaked audio clips were not sent for forensic examination

Manipur.

It had directed that the entire available leaked audio be forwarded to the NFSU, Gandhinagar, for forensic examination.

“The entire 48 minutes of the conversation in question, along with the admitted voice recordings of the former Manipur chief minister, are available.. All the voice recordings furnished to the respondents by the learned counsel for the petitioner shall also be included therewith and forwarded to the National Forensic Science University in Gandhinagar,” the bench had

ordered then.

It had also asked the NFSU to expedite the process and submit the final report in a sealed cover. The top court had said that the audio clips in question may be examined to determine whether they were modified, edited or tampered with in any manner.

It had also asked the NFSU to determine whether the voice in the disputed audio clips matched the voice in the admitted audio clips, to give a clear finding that it was the same person who was speaking in all the

audio clips.

On December 15 last year, the bench questioned why the entire available leaked audio clips were not sent for forensic examination.

The top court had said that it was a “little disturbed” by the affidavit filed on behalf of the petitioners on November 20, 2025, that “states to the effect that only select clippings were sent”.

The NFSU had earlier virtually given a clean chit, saying the leaked audio clips were “tampered with”.

Singh resigned as the chief minister of Manipur on February 9 last year, amid rumblings within the state BJP and growing demands for a change in leadership.

The apex court was hearing the petition filed by the Kuki Organisation for Human Rights Trust (KOHUR), which has sought an independent SIT probe into the matter.

Jammu–Srinagar Vande Bharat Express flagged off by Vaishnaw

Railway minister promises rail link to Poonch, Uri

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SRINAGAR: As the first direct Vande Bharat Express from Jammu chugged into the Kashmir valley on Thursday, Railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw promised to focus on connecting remote areas like Poonch, Rajouri and Uri to the country's rail network.

Following the completion of the ambitious Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL), Vaishnaw said detailed project reports (DPRs) have been prepared on projects to connect the Poonch-Rajouri region to the national rail network and to extend the railway line to Uri, a border town in Baramulla district.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah and Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office, Jitendra Singh, were among the dignitaries present at the flagging off ceremony.

The direct train services between Srinagar and Jammu will reduce travel time between the twin capitals of Jammu



Union ministers Ashwini Vaishnaw, Jitendra Singh and Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah during the flagging off ceremony of the extended Srinagar-Katra Vande Bharat Express from Jammu Tawi Railway Station (JAT), in Jammu district, Thursday

and Kashmir, and boost tourism, besides providing an all-weather surface transport link.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the first direct train service between Katra and Srinagar on June 6, 2025. This service has now been extended up to the Jammu Tawi Railway Station.

The work on the Rs 43,780-crore rail project, linking Kashmir to the rest of the country, began in the late 1990s, with the first train operating in the Kash-

mir Valley in October 2008.

Talking to reporters after the flagging off ceremony, Vaishnaw said the government will focus on connecting the Poonch-Rajouri region with the rail network of the country, besides working on a rail link to Uri.

“We will now focus on connecting Poonch and Rajouri with rail connectivity. We will also take up a project to connect Uri with the train,” the minister said after the flagging off ceremony.

CM Saini invites Punjab industrialists to set up industries in Haryana

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that the state government is formulating a comprehensive and future-oriented industrial policy, keeping in view the interests of the industry. The primary objective of this policy is to establish Haryana as a leading industrial hub of the country, attract maximum investment and generate large-scale employment opportunities for the youth of the state, he said.

Saini further informed that suggestions have been formally invited from industry stakeholders to make the policy practical and effective, thereby ensuring tangible improvements at the ground level.

The CM was interacting with prominent industrialists from Punjab at his residence, Sant Kabir Kutir. On this occasion, the industrialists honoured the Chief Minister with a memento and held detailed discussions on various issues related to industry, investment, and employment. The meeting aimed at promoting inter-state industrial cooperation and strengthening avenues for shared growth.

Saini said that Haryana today ranks among the fastest-growing states in the country and is steadily progressing towards becoming the leading state in the nation. He said that every district of the state is well connected through a robust road network and national highways, which has created a favourable environment for industries and trade.

He further informed that the

Haryana Vidhan Sabha organises training workshop for MLAs

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Haryana Vidhan Sabha on Thursday organised a training workshop for MLAs at Haryana Niwas, Sector 3.

The workshop, held under the guidance of Haryana Vidhan Sabha Speaker Harvinder Kalyan, provided in-depth training to legislators on the subject “Parliamentary Committees – Role of Members” through expert sessions.

Addressing the legislators at the inaugural session, Vidhan Sabha Speaker Harvinder Kalyan said that strengthening democratic institutions is essential to achieve Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of “Viksit Bharat 2047”.

He said that public representatives should place public welfare above all else and present their views with a deep understanding of rules, procedures, and legislative work.

state government is developing Industrial Model Townships (IMTs) at various locations, and the processes of land acquisition and infrastructure development are being carried out at a rapid pace.

UP: Man throws 4-year-old son into Yamuna over dispute with wife

FIROZABAD: A man allegedly killed his four-year-old son by throwing him into the Yamuna river following a dispute with his wife, before jumping in himself, police said on Thursday.

The incident occurred on Wednesday evening under the Basai Mohammadpur police station area.

The accused, Triloki, reached Shankarpur ghat and pushed his son, Anand, into the river before leaping in himself. While Triloki was rescued by people working in nearby fields, Anand could not be traced immediately.

Police were informed and local divers later discovered the child's body from downstream after a search operation, police said. Station House Officer Kripal Singh said preliminary investigation suggests that the man took the extreme step in a fit of rage following a domestic dispute.

The body has been sent for a post-mortem and further investigation is underway, he said.

AGENCIES

‘Quality playgrounds, strong education key to steering youth towards purpose, performance’

CM Mann lays foundation stone of Rs 14.63 crore sports stadium in Sangrur

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday laid the foundation stone of a Rs 14.63 crore modern sports stadium in Sangrur, setting the tone for a decisive push to transform Punjab's youth landscape through sports, health, and discipline.

Positioned as both an infrastructure upgrade and a social intervention, the world-class facility coming up on 4.38 acres in Satouj will offer professional training and host a wide range of sports including Badminton, Handball, Judo, Netball, Basketball, Volleyball, Foot-



ball, Gymnastics, Kabaddi and Karate.

Pushing sports as a direct counter to the drug menace, CM Mann underscored that expanding access to quality playgrounds alongside strong

education systems is key to steering youth towards purpose, performance, and global achievement, while building a healthier Punjab.

Calling it a historic day for the region, Mann said, “It is a

ED confiscates Rs 1.4 crore in probe linked to former Punjab DIG

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: On Thursday raids unfolded across eleven sites in Chandigarh and parts of Punjab. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) seized Rs 1.4 crore. Actions followed an ongoing probe into financial misconduct tied to Harcharan Singh Bhullar, ex-deputy inspector general (DIG) of Punjab Police.

Investigations focus on suspected layers of illegal fund movement. Cash seizure forms part of broader scrutiny into hidden asset trails. Locations ranged from residential buildings to office spaces.

Evidence collection occurred under legal warrants

Evidence collection occurred under legal warrants

executed simultaneously. Oversight remains active as procedural steps continue. Findings may feed into larger patterns detected elsewhere. Monetary assets now held by federal investigative units.

A raid conducted on April 27 formed one phase of a continuing investigation into claims of bribe-taking and unexplained wealth accumulation. Evidence in the form of documents pointing toward

wrongdoing emerged during searches at locations tied to Bhullar. Among those places were offices belonging to associates, real estate agents, and firms believed to be acting as fronts. The Enforcement Directorate confirmed the seizure occurred without prior public notice.

The investigation stems from an FIR registered by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Anti-Corruption Branch, Chandigarh.

Following Akash Batta's report, it emerged that Bhullar was said to have sought payment via a middleman – this, to prevent firm enforcement measures tied to issues in the complainant's recycling operations.

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday launched a sharp attack on the Samajwadi Party and Congress while addressing a one-day special session of the state legislature convened over the women's reservation amendment Bill.

Opening his speech, Adityanath said that when Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched the Jan Dhan scheme in the name of women, leaders of SP had mocked it and questioned the promise of Rs 15 lakh.

He said those very bank accounts became a support system for women during the Covid pandemic when finan-

SAJID KHAN

SHAHJAHANPUR: At least seven people were killed and several others injured in two separate road accidents in Shahjahanpur district on Thursday, police said.

In the first incident, four members of a family lost their lives in the Puwayan police station area near Delhi Public School after a speeding Bolero collided head-on with a motorcycle.

The victims were identified as Arun, his wife Seema and their two children Diksha, 6, and Naitik, 4. They were returning home from a wedding in the Nigohi area when the accident took place.

According to eyewitnesses, the impact of the collision threw all four off the motorcycle. Arun and the children died on the spot, while Seema was taken to a nearby hospital where doctors later declared her dead.

Police have seized the Bolero and sent the bodies for post-mortem. Circle Officer Praveen Malik said legal proceedings have been initiated and an investigation is underway.

In another accident in the Khutar area near Rautapur Kala village, three people including a newly married woman were killed and four others injured after a speeding tanker collided with a car coming from the opposite direction.

Yogi targets SP, Cong in UP special session over women’s reservation Bill



Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath during the special one-day session of the state Assembly, in Lucknow, Thursday

cial assistance was directly transferred.

The Chief Minister said the construction of 12 crore toilets across the country ensured dignity and safety for women, but alleged that SP leaders ridiculed

the initiative and were never sensitive towards women's honour. He added that these toilets symbolised women's dignity.

Adityanath accused the Opposition of demanding 33 per cent reservation only after facing public anger, remarking that their conduct would put even a chameleon to shame.

Highlighting welfare schemes, he said 10 crore women were provided LPG connections under the BJP government and that women have played a significant role in the startup ecosystem launched under Modi's leadership.

He also referred to schemes aimed at economic empowerment, including the Lakhpati Didi initiative.

Too little too late, says Warring on special session on ‘Labour Day’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Asserting that the Aam Aadmi Party government in Punjab was not sincere to anybody including the labourers, Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring today said that the special session of the Punjab Vidhan Sabha to mark the ‘Labour Day’ was a “characteristic theatrical diversionary tactic” of the ruling party as it was faced with an existential threat after defection of seven MPs. “Besides, it is too little and too late”, he remarked.

The PCC president asked what purpose will the “special sessions” serve for the labourers, when the govt is on the last leg of its tenure and that too crippled.

“When the govt is not sure of its own survival and existence, what can it do for the labourers?” he asked, while noting that the AAP has been holding “special sessions” so frequently to divert the attention and shrug off its responsibility that such sessions have lost their “specialty” of being special. “You don’t hold special sessions more frequently than the regular sessions”, he

remarked.

Warring asked the government what has it done for the labourers during the last four years. The fact is that Punjab under the AAP government was the worst performing state on MGNREGA, he said, while disclosing that not even fifty per cent registered labourers had been covered under the scheme during the last four years and not even one per cent of them had got 100 days mandatory work.

He said that it is obvious that the AAP's purpose in holding the session was not to deliberate or pass any special law for the welfare of labourers, but to dodge and divert the public attention from the existential crisis it is faced with after the defection of its seven Rajya Sabha members, six of whom are from Punjab.

Maintaining that this ‘special session’ will also end up as a damp squib like the previous ones, the PCC president said, he did not expect anything from it, except a token expression of concern for the welfare of the labour without any substance or time bound roadmap.



Students celebrate after the declaration of the ICSE Board Class 10th and ISC 12th results, in Dehradun, Thursday

of 99.26 per cent, followed by Other Backward Classes (99.24 per cent), Scheduled Tribes (98.07 per cent) and Scheduled Castes (98.76 per cent).

In ISC, general category students registered a 99.17 per cent pass rate, Other Backward Classes 99.12 per cent, Scheduled Castes 98.77 per cent and

Scheduled Tribes 98.84 per cent.

The examinations were conducted across 67 subjects in ICSE and 45 subjects in ISC.

The results are available on the official CISCE website (cisce.org).

Meanwhile, Shambhavi Tiwari, a resident of Jharkhand,

scored 100 in all of her ‘best of four’ subjects in the Indian School Certificate (ISC) examination for class 12 conducted by the CISCE.

Tiwari, who is one of the toppers in the ISC examination, told news agency that she aspires to become a neurosurgeon and her imme-

Key Points

» About 1,03,316 students took the ISC, or Class 12, exam

» In the ICSE exam, 2,56,590 candidates qualified, while 2,131 did not clear the exam

» In the ISC exam, 1,02,414 candidates qualified, while 902 did not

» The examinations were conducted across 67 subjects in ICSE and 45 subjects in ISC

» Shambhavi Tiwari, a resident of Jharkhand, scored 100 in all of her ‘best of four’ subjects in the ISC examination for class 12 conducted by the CISCE

diate goal is to succeed in the NEET exam to be held on May 3.

The resident of Adityapur in Seraikela Kharsawan district secured 100 per cent marks in English, Physics, Chemistry and Biology -- her best of four subjects.

British Jews are scared: UK PM Keir Starmer

Pointing out that liberal British values are not a gift handed down

In his appeal, Starmer cautioned that calls for "globalise the intifada" during the anti-Israel marches in Britain were akin to a call for "ter-

Starmer went on to reiterate the new measures the government has already set in place, including strengthening the vis-

AGENCIES

We will prevent hate preachers from entering our country, bar them from our campuses, our streets, our communities, [and] work with our justice system to speed up sentencing on antisemitic attacks so there is a stronger deterrence factor, as we do with riots,”

"I call on everyone to fight for the decent, respectful, tolerant Britain that I and millions of people love so that our freedom and our values can still speak loud and true to a community that can no longer take it on faith," he noted.

AGENCI

OUR CENSUS, OUR DEVELOPMENT

(First Phase of Census 2027)

Houselisting and Housing Census by the Government of India is about to begin in your State/Union Territory. Before this, a 15-day special facility is being provided where you can fill in your information online yourself.

I am
Pragati

SELF-ENUMERATION

Simple and Secure Digital facility

I am
Vikas

How to do Self-Enumeration?

- 1 Visit the official portal (se.census.gov.in)
- 2 Login via OTP using your mobile number
- 3 Select your State, District and Local details
- 4 Mark your house location on the Digital Map
- 5 Fill in information related to the house and family
- 6 You will receive an SE ID after submission
- 7 Keep the SE ID safe
- 8 Provide the SE ID to the enumerator when they visit
- 9 The enumerator will confirm the information

It's Benefits

- Time-Saving
- Accurate Information
- Fast Data Processing

Remember: Self-enumeration is a special facility

If you are unable to self-enumerate, do not worry; an enumerator will definitely visit your home during the scheduled period to record the information.

All your information will remain completely confidential and secure.

Delhi (Municipal Corporation of Delhi)

Self-Enumeration

1st – 15th May

Houselisting

16th May – 14th June

*Self-Enumeration period is over for New Delhi Municipal Council and Delhi Cantonment Board areas. Houselisting process is currently underway and will continue till 15th May.

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CBC 19108/13/0071/2627

AHEAD OF STRIKES

Israeli military tells residents of eight Lebanese towns to leave

BEIRUT: The Israeli military warned residents of eight Lebanese towns outside of the “buffer zone” to leave their homes immediately on Thursday ahead of strikes.

The “buffer zone” in southern Lebanon was occupied by Israeli troops before a ceasefire that was announced earlier this month but has failed to fully halt hostilities.

Meanwhile, more than 1 million people in Lebanon are expected to face a food insecurity crisis in the months ahead as a result of renewed conflict and mass displacement, a global hunger monitor said on Wednesday.

A new analysis by the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) has found that 1.24 million will be unable to consistently meet basic food needs and will be forced to reduce the quality and quantity



UN peacekeepers operate in southern Lebanon

AP/PTI

of foods consumed, or resort to harmful coping strategies to survive.

“These results underscore the severity of the current situation in Lebanon, where conflict intersects with economic pressures putting national food security under critical risk and

junction,” said Nora Ourabah Haddad, the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations’ representative in Lebanon.

The nearly two-month war between Israel and Lebanese armed group Hezbollah has displaced more than 1.2 mil-

Highlights

- » The ‘buffer zone’ in southern Lebanon was occupied by Israeli troops
- » Meanwhile, over 1 million people in Lebanon are expected to face a food insecurity crisis in months
- » More than 76% of south Lebanon’s farmers have been displaced and 22% of all agricultural land damaged in the latest bout of fighting

lion people in Lebanon, with many heads of households out of work and relying on donations to survive as the regional conflict drives up food prices.

The latest conflict erupted on March 2, when Hezbollah launched rockets at Israel in support of its backer Iran. Israel

has responded with heavy airstrikes and a ground invasion.

More than 2,500 people have been killed in Israeli strikes since, and Israel still occupies large swathes of the south as part of a self-declared buffer zone.

The IPC said Lebanon’s agricultural sector, once a critical source of food and income, has suffered from damage to farmland, displacement of farmers and rising input costs.

More than 76% of south Lebanon’s farmers have been displaced and 22% of all agricultural land damaged in the latest bout of fighting, according to Lebanon’s agriculture ministry.

It remains unclear how many will be able to return after a shaky ceasefire took hold earlier this month, reducing but not entirely halting hostilities.

AGENCIES

Pak says it’s actively engaged with US and Iran to end war

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Thursday said that it was actively engaged with the US and Iran to end the war in West Asia and restore peace and stability in the region and beyond.

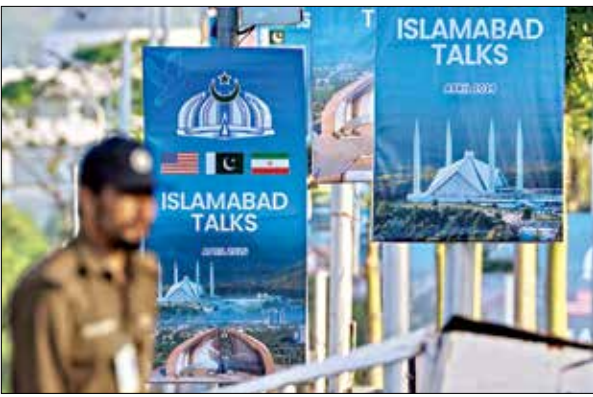
“Anything that passes through the conduit of diplomatic channels in Pakistan is honestly communicated to the other side,” Foreign Office Spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said at the weekly briefing.

He added that the clock on diplomacy has not stopped but is functional.

“We are in contact with the relevant parties on the matter. Regarding negotiations, both new and old proposals are on the table. We hope peace will prevail,” Andrabi said, referring to efforts to bring about an end to hostilities between the two countries.

Andrabi said that Pakistan was hopeful of a negotiated settlement of this issue, emphasising that “we encourage direct negotiations between the two sides.”

He expressed hope for “sta-



A police officer walks past posters of US and Iran talks

AP/PTI

“EVEN THE US NEGOTIATORS WERE READY TO VISIT ISLAMABAD FOR TALKS, BUT THE MEETING COULD NOT HAPPEN”

ble relations between Iran and the US”.

The statement came after the second round of talks between the US and Iran could

not materialise despite Pakistan’s hectic efforts to bring the two sides to the negotiating table.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi made two brief visits to Pakistan within 48 hours over the weekend, meeting with Field Marshal Asim Munir and PM Shehbaz Sharif to discuss the regional situation.

Even the US negotiators were ready to visit Islamabad for talks, but the meeting could not happen.

AGENCIES

Zelenskyy says he’s seeking details of Putin’s May 9 ceasefire proposal



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

KYIV: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy is seeking details of a short-term ceasefire Russia proposed to U.S. President Donald Trump, he said in a post on Telegram on Thursday. Russian President Vladimir Putin proposed a May 9 ceasefire to coincide with Victory Day in Russia in a phone call with Trump the previous day, according to the Kremlin.

“We have instructed our representatives to contact the United States president’s team and clarify the details of the Russian proposal for a short-term ceasefire,” Zelenskyy said.

Meanwhile, Russian attacks overnight killed one person in the central Ukrainian city of Dnipro and wounded dozens more in the southern port city of Odesa, as Ukraine continued to strike industrial facilities inside Russian territory for a second day in a row. A ship that created a brief diplomatic scuffle between Israel and Ukraine has departed Israel without unloading what Zelenskyy said

‘We have instructed our representatives to contact the United States president’s team and clarify the details of the Russian proposal for a short-term ceasefire’

were grains Russia stole from occupied areas of Ukraine, Ukrainian officials said.

Putin’s aide Yuri Ushakov said that the Russian president had discussed a ceasefire for the May 9 holiday, when Russia celebrates victory over Nazi Germany in World War II, during a phone call with Trump Wednesday. But Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said Thursday that no definite decision had been made, and that it would be for Putin to decide on the specific terms.

GENERATIONAL SHIFT

Teens embrace social media for news but remain skeptical

NEW YORK: Teenagers are more inclined than their elders to get news from nontraditional sources such as social media and influencers, heralding a generational shift in how people seek out information.

A national study by the Media Insight Project finds 36 per cent of US adults say they get news from social media at least once a day. But for people ages 13 to 17, that number rises to 57 per cent.

Similarly, 43 per cent of adults say they get information on national issues and events from influencers or independent content creators at least “sometimes,” compared with 57 per cent of teenagers. The project is a collaboration among The Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research, the American Press Institute and journalism schools at Northwestern University and the University of Maryland.

The new poll points to the pervasiveness of social media in teenagers’ lives and shows how more teens are consuming their news from these platforms or independent content



Besides social media, teenagers are also more likely to turn to search engines and artificial intelligence chatbots as they hunt for news

creators, rather than directly from national or local news sources.

While Americans haven’t abandoned traditional journalism, they are reevaluating what sources they trust, said Robyn Tomlin, executive director of the American Press

following the restoration of full diplomatic relations with Venezuela.

“I’m very excited to go and see the family and I’m looking forward to see the country,” said passenger Lennart Ochoa of Miami shortly before boarding.

He said that he was “ready to go” and got his ticket as soon as they were available. “Just to go and see the family on a direct flight from Miami to Caracas is priceless.”

American Airlines staff handed passengers small Venezuelan flags. Balloons with its colors — yellow, blue and red — adorned the gate door leading to the plane.

AGENCIES

Sri Lanka: Govt official suspended over cyber fraud found dead

COLOMBO: A senior Sri Lankan official, suspended in connection with the loss of USD 2.5 million due to hacking of the Finance Ministry account, was found dead in Kuliyapitiya, police said on Thursday.

The unnamed official, posted as an Assistant Director at the External Resources Department (ERD) of the Ministry of Finance, was one of the six officials suspended pending an investigation into the cyber fraud. Police suspect that the official may have committed suicide in his house at Kuliyapitiya in the northwest region.

Last week, the secretary to the Treasury confirmed that USD 2.5 million from the Treasury account meant for foreign debt repayment to Australia was hacked in January.

This was a part payment of the USD 22.9 million debt settlement.

Meanwhile, Secretary to the Treasury Harshana Suriyapera appeared before the Parliament’s Committee on Public Finance (COPF) in connection with the case.



॥ बुद्धम् शरणम् गच्छामि ॥

बुद्ध पूर्णिमा

की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं

“ बुद्ध बोध भी हैं और शोध भी हैं। बुद्ध विचार भी हैं और संस्कार भी हैं। ”

-नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री

नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री

रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यामंत्री, दिल्ली

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/15/26-27



EDITORIAL
STRATEGIC
EXIT

UAE's decision to exit both OPEC and the broader OPEC+ alliance from May 1 is more than a routine policy shift; it is a signal that the architecture of global oil governance is entering a more uncertain phase. For decades, OPEC has functioned as a mechanism through which oil-producing nations coordinated supply to stabilise prices and protect collective interests. The UAE's withdrawal challenges that premise. It underscores a growing divergence within producer nations, where national economic strategies are beginning to outweigh the logic of collective discipline. In an era marked by geopolitical volatility, energy transition pressures, and shifting market dynamics, this move raises a fundamental question: can traditional producer alliances still hold together, or are we witnessing the gradual fragmentation of the oil order?

To appreciate the significance of the UAE's decision, one must understand its position within the global energy system. The country is not merely a participant in OPEC; it is among the world's top ten oil producers and one of the most technologically advanced in terms of extraction and export capabilities. Accounting for roughly 4 per cent of global oil production and possessing the ability to ramp up output by close to one million barrels per day, the UAE has both the capacity and the incentive to act independently. Under OPEC's quota system, such capacity has often been constrained in the interest of price stability. By stepping outside this framework, the UAE is effectively reclaiming its autonomy to respond directly to market signals. In principle, this introduces a more competitive dynamic into global oil markets, which could, over time, exert downward pressure on prices. Yet, the translation of this structural shift into real-world outcomes is far from straightforward.

The immediate context in which this decision unfolds is defined by acute geopolitical disruption. The ongoing tensions involving Iran have already placed enormous strain on the global oil supply chain, particularly through the Strait of Hormuz, a critical chokepoint that typically handles nearly a fifth of the world's oil and gas shipments. With shipping traffic severely disrupted, the ability of producers to bring additional supply to market is constrained, regardless of their production capacity. For UAE, alternative export routes such as the pipeline to the Port of Fujairah provide some flexibility, but they cannot fully compensate for disruptions in the strait. This means that the country's newfound production freedom is unlikely to translate into a significant increase in global supply. Consequently, expectations of immediate relief in oil prices may prove misplaced.

However, oil markets are shaped as much by expectations as by actual supply and demand. The announcement of the UAE's exit itself carries signalling power. Market participants—ranging from traders and institutional investors to governments and energy firms—constantly interpret such developments to anticipate future price movements. If the exit is perceived as a precursor to increased production and a loosening of supply constraints, it could exert downward pressure on futures prices even before any additional barrels enter the market. Conversely, if it is interpreted as evidence of growing discord within OPEC+ and a potential breakdown of coordinated supply management, it could heighten uncertainty and volatility.

UAE's move also invites a broader reassessment of OPEC's relevance in today's energy landscape. The organisation was founded in 1960 with the explicit aim of harmonising petroleum policies and stabilising markets. For much of its history, it has succeeded, albeit imperfectly, in exercising significant influence over global oil prices through coordinated production decisions. Yet, the world it operates in today is markedly different. The rise of non-OPEC producers, particularly the United States with its shale revolution, has diluted the group's market power. At the same time, internal differences among members—driven by varying fiscal needs, production capacities, and geopolitical alignments—have made consensus more difficult to achieve. The expansion of OPEC+ to include countries like Russia was itself an acknowledgement of these shifting realities. The exit can be seen as both a symptom and a catalyst of change, highlighting the limits of collective action in an increasingly fragmented environment.

For India, these developments carry significant implications. India's economic stability is closely tied to global oil prices, which influence inflation, fiscal balances, and the broader macroeconomic environment. In the medium term, the possibility of increased competition among producers could offer some relief by moderating prices. However, the more immediate concern is volatility. Unpredictable price swings complicate policy planning, strain public finances, and create uncertainty for businesses and consumers alike. UAE's decision to introduce an additional layer of unpredictability into the market, reinforces the need for India to accelerate efforts toward energy diversification, strategic reserves, and the transition to alternative sources of energy. Where once stability was maintained through relatively cohesive producer alliances, today's landscape is shaped by a complex interplay of national interests, geopolitical tensions, technological shifts, and financial speculation. The notion of a single group exerting decisive control over prices is increasingly difficult to sustain.

UAE's exit is thus not merely an isolated decision; it is indicative of a broader transformation. It reflects a world in which traditional frameworks are being tested by new realities, and where the balance between cooperation and competition is constantly in flux. The era of predictable oil markets may be drawing to a close, and the UAE's decision could well be one of the clearest signals yet that a new, less certain chapter has begun.

POLICY
WATCH



SHILOHU RAO

THE WRITER IS A PROFESSOR & RESEARCH DIRECTOR, CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE, NATIONAL LAW UNIVERSITY, JODHPUR

With public consultation open, citizens must weigh whether the new IT Rules strengthen accountability or create uncertainty around lawful online expression

Imagine an ordinary Indian who may be a student, a farmer, or a small journalist posting a video about a local election, a crop-price protest, or a school grievance on X, Facebook, or Instagram. Millions do this every single day. Yet, under the government's proposed amendments to the IT Rules, notified on March 30, 2026, such posts could suddenly be labelled “news and current affairs”? Would platforms then have to obey new Ministry directions or lose their legal protection?

But the changes themselves deserve a calm, honest look from every citizen. The Ministry has extended the deadline for public comments till May 7, 2026. This willingness from the Ministry to listen is a welcome step.

What the amendments aim to do

The government wants an “open, safe, trusted and accountable” internet. The draft requires platforms to follow any written clarification, advisory, or direction issued by the Ministry. It brings ordinary user posts that qualify as “news and current affairs” under the same strict oversight that applies to professional media. It also clarifies data retention and expands the role of the government's oversight committee.

The purpose of the proposed amendments is to enable effective regulation of deepfakes, hate speech, and deliberate misinformation, which spread rapidly and have the potential to cause real-world harm and disrupt public order. The proposed amendments intend to arm the authorities with necessary legal tools, which are reasonable within the ambit of Article 19(2) of the Constitution of India and the Information Technology Act, 2000.



This is the moment for every Indian to speak clearly, factually, and without fear

Why every citizen should participate

The real issue is to achieve a reasonable balance in the freedom of speech and expression guaranteed under Article 19(1) (a) for our citizens. Any restriction on freedom of speech and expression must be clear and reasonable, and, to the best possible extent, the authorities must exercise great restraint in any attempt to impose restrictions on freedom of speech and expression. The Supreme Court of India defended this position and principle in the Shreya Singhal judgment, wherein

Section 66A of the IT Act was held unconstitutional, precisely because of its vague language.

Former Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud, in the M.C. Chagla Memorial Lecture on “Speaking Truth to Power,” argued that the ability of citizens to speak truth to those in authority is integral to democracy. This spirit of fearless expression is not new to India. In the *Ramayana*, the sage Jabali openly questioned Prince Rama's decisions with rational dissent, yet faced no punishment. In the *Mahabharata*, the wise minister Vidura repeatedly spoke uncomfortable truths to King Dhritrashtra, warning him against injustice even at personal risk. These factual incidents from our epics show

that the courage to speak one's mind, even to those in power, has long been part of our civilisational ethos.

A modern, smarter solution

We do need strong protection against real harms—deepfakes, hate speech, and proven misinformation. But relying only on a government committee to examine every “matter” is not the best way forward in the AI era. Instead, intermediaries may be permitted to deploy unbiased Explainable AI as their first transparent responder to audit the content posted on their platforms. This would screen content only for clearly defined illegal and harmful material—deepfakes, direct incitement to violence, or information that meets strict legal

tests of falsehood. The Explainable AI must explain its reasoning in plain language to both the user and the platform before any content is restricted. Only when the AI flags a serious violation would human committee review, followed by judicial oversight, come into play.

This hybrid approach would let every citizen express themselves freely and repose their trust in the government's intentions to make such amendments. Our ancient texts reveal that Jabali and Vidura were permitted to express dissenting, even atheistic, arguments, perfectly illustrating the ancient tolerance for intellectual freedom. These incidents represent documented ethical and ancient political traditions that prevailed in our culture.

Our nation has both the constitutional wisdom and the technological prowess to lead the world. Our digital rules will honour that ancient tradition without undermining it. The proposed rules will be seen as enablers of ordinary voices with this approach and will no longer be chilled by vague directions or fear of over-removal. In my view, the 2021 IT Rules were a bold first step, and the 2026 amendments are the next. Let us ensure this step strengthens both safety and liberty by embracing transparent, explainable technology that serves the citizen, not silences them.

This is the moment for every Indian to speak clearly, factually, and without fear. Let the final rules truly reflect the best of our Constitution and our timeless tradition of open discourse.

Views expressed are personal

POLL
PULSE



SUTAPA MUKHERJEE

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR, EDUCATIONIST AND MENTAL HEALTH COUNSELLOR

Bengal recorded a historic 92.47% voter turnout across two phases—its highest since Independence. Yet, the campaign narrative diverged sharply from traditional governance debates

West Bengal has scripted history with a 92.47 per cent voter turnout—the highest ever recorded in the state since Independence across the two-phase Assembly elections held on April 23 and 29. And just like that, the fever has broken. A sudden lull descends. The thumping campaign songs have faded, the limericks no longer ripple through the air, and the electrifying slogans and fiery challenges have fallen silent. What remains is a pregnant pause, laced with speculation. Green or orange?

This time, the campaign carried a distinctly different flavour, acquiring layers of symbolism as it unfolded. It is striking how the two principal contenders—the All India Trinamool Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party—are represented by botanical emblems that seem almost metaphorically contrasting. One is rooted firmly in the fertile soil—the grass and jora phool that have become synonymous with Bengal's landscape—evoking the wider green of the countryside. The other, the lotus, floats gracefully on water, steeped in religious symbolism and long associated with Hindu mythology.

Yet the real soundtrack of the rallies told a more complex story. From one podium rose the thunderous chant of “Jai Shri Ram”, a slogan that has echoed since the 1980s but now resonates with renewed political intensity. From the other soared “Joy Bangla”, once a triumphant cry of liberation, now repurposed with defiant energy. For those old enough to remember the early 1970s, the phrase carries a curious mix of nostalgia and mischief. In the years following the creation of Bangladesh, when I was still a wide-eyed child in Kolkata, a wave of conjunctivitis swept through the city. The red, watery eyes became so common that locals jokingly dubbed the affliction “Joy Bangla”. In much the same way, the slogan during this campaign seemed to act as an irritant to the saffron brigade—a persistent itch that refused to subside.

To counter “Jai Shri Ram”, leaders from the Trinamool camp were seen singing songs invoking Allah and the Kaaba with surprising ease. For those unfamiliar with Bengal's cultural history, these soulful renditions belong to Bhatiali—the haunting folk music of boatmen that has echoed across Bengal's rivers for generations, carried largely by the Muslim communities of the delta and coastal stretches. It was a remarkable sight: prominent leaders, microphones in hand, rendering these timeless melo-



As the noise recedes, what lingers is a more unsettling question—what exactly did this election debate, and what did it leave unsaid?

dies on dusty stages and crowded maidans, blending politics with the rhythm of tide and oar.

The religious mosaic did not end there. There were recitations from the Chandipath, chants of the Hanuman Chalisa, verses from the Kalma, and in Bhabanipur—home to a sizeable Sikh population—the serene strains of Gurbani. Religion, it seemed, had once again seeped deep into the fabric of Indian electoral politics, not as a quiet undercurrent but as a visible, performative presence.

That Bengalis are an inherently creative people is beyond doubt. The impromptu limericks that filled the campaign trail with impeccable rhythm and wit will certainly be missed. They lent the election a distinct cultural flavour, turning political messaging into an art form.

Having covered elections for decades, I have rarely witnessed a campaign quite like this. The battleground appeared to shift away from development and governance, settling instead onto the dining table. Leaders sparred over food habits—non-vegetarian versus vegetarian—with the noble *ilish* and the everyday *rui* suddenly acquiring political significance. One side warned that a certain ideological shift might one day drive fish out of the Bengali thali altogether, turning cherished Sunday lunches into dry, joyless affairs. The other countered with carefully curated images of the Prime

Minister enjoying *ghal muri* under the midday sun, as though the sharp tang of mustard oil on puffed rice alone could certify one's *Bangaliyana*.

It was particularly striking how the humble *ghal muri* was elevated to the status of a cultural litmus test. In tea stalls from Bhabanipur to Behala, animated addas unfolded not over jobs or infrastructure, but over whether one could truly claim to understand Bengal without relishing that crisp, tangy snack on a humid afternoon. I kept expecting the all-favourite puchka to enter the fray—after all, the eternal Bengali *puchka*-versus-North Indian *gol gappa* debate carries enough spice to fuel another campaign—but, perhaps wisely, it remained outside the arena. One stray remark could have opened an entirely new, unnecessarily messy, and sour front.

As polling day unfolded on April 29, beneath the shade of old banyan trees and the weathered walls of the once-prestigious Mitra Institution in Bhabanipur, the familiar frenzy gave way to quiet determination. Since 2011, this constituency has remained a Trinamool stronghold, closely associated with its leader, Mamata Banerjee. Long queues snaked patiently through the lanes of Chakraberia, where only days earlier loudspeakers had blared, and flags fluttered in green and saffron. By evening, Bhabanipur recorded a remarkable turnout exceeding 90 per cent—a new local

benchmark within an already historic statewide surge.

Inked fingers rose like quiet badges of participation as voters emerged from polling booths—elderly women in crisp cotton saris adjusting their pallus, young professionals pausing for selfies, first-time voters wearing their enthusiasm on their sleeves. Central forces maintained a steady and disciplined vigil, their presence underscoring the high stakes. The Chief Minister and her challenger hovered briefly within the same ward, exchanging indirect barbs without a direct encounter—a familiar choreography in Bengal's intense yet curiously civil political theatre.

Away from the national spotlight, however, the deeper story remains stubbornly, unmistakably Bengali—a rich blend of fish and folklore, argument and affection, politics and adda over endless cups of tea. One is reminded of Amartya Sen and his evocative idea of *The Argumentative Indian*—a society that thrives on debate, disagreement, and dialogue.

The loudspeakers have now fallen silent. The makeshift stages stand deserted, and the restless processions have dissolved into memory. Bengal waits—in living rooms, in tea stalls, in quiet conversations and whispered predictions. It is a pause heavy with anticipation, that peculiar democratic silence which holds its breath until the final verdict arrives.

Views expressed are personal

WEAK GLOBAL TRENDS

Sensex settles 582 pts lower as high oil prices dent investor sentiment

OUR CORRESPONDENT

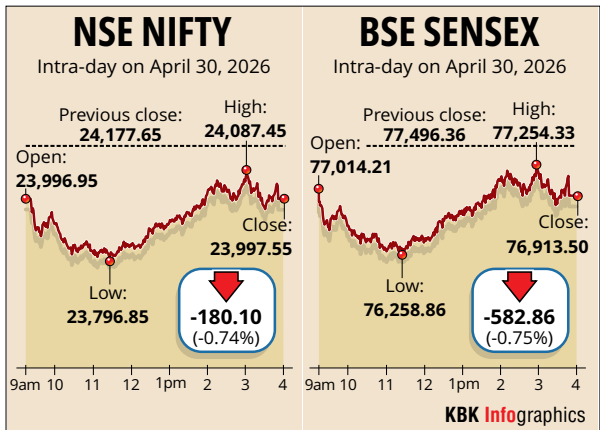
MUMBAI: Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty closed nearly 1 per cent lower on Thursday as crude oil prices, weak global trends and foreign fund outflows weighed on investor sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 582.86 points or 0.75 per cent to settle at 76,913.50. During the day, it plunged 1,237.5 points, or 1.59 per cent, to 76,258.86, but recovered some of the losses in the second half of the session.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dived 180.10 points or 0.74 per cent to end at 23,997.55.

Among the 30-Sensex firms, Eternal, Hindustan Unilever, Tata Steel, Larsen & Toubro, UltraTech Cement and Mahindra & Mahindra were the major laggards.

Sun Pharma, Infosys, Bajaj Finance and Adani Ports were among the gainers.



Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 1.52 per cent lower at USD 116.2 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 2,468.42 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

In broader markets, the BSE MidCap Select index dropped 0.84 per cent and the BSE

SmallCap Select index declined 0.58 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, metal tanked the most by 2.13 per cent, followed by PSU Bank (1.66 per cent), Realty (1.44 per cent), Commodities (1.36 per cent), FMCG (1.13 per cent), Financial Services (1.08 per cent) and Industrials (1.05 per cent).

A total of 2,532 stocks

HIGHLIGHTS

» During the day, Sensex plunged 1,237.5 pts, or 1.59%, to 76,258.86, but recovered some of the losses in the second half of the session

» The 50-share NSE Nifty dived 180.10 pts or 0.74% to end at 23,997.55

» Markets will remain closed on Friday

trading mixed. US markets ended mostly lower on Wednesday.

“Brent crude crossed the USD 120 per barrel mark for the first time in four years, intensifying inflation concerns and pressuring global risk assets. In India, rising oil prices weighed on the INR and revived worries about capital outflows and widening deficits, given the economy’s heavy reliance on crude imports.

“The Fed kept rates unchanged but maintained a firm policy stance, supporting the dollar and tightening conditions for emerging markets. Domestically, autos, banks, metals, and real estate led the decline, while IT and pharma saw selective defensive buying,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

Stock and forex markets will remain closed on Friday for Maharashtra Day.

DPIIT Secy says FDI inflows ‘may hit \$90 billion in FY26’

FDI easing for foreign companies with up to 10 per cent Chinese stake to be notified soon under FEMA: Officials

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The decision to ease foreign direct investment norms for overseas companies with up to 10 per cent stake in Chinese companies will be notified soon under the FEMA law, a senior government official said on Thursday.

In March, the Union Cabinet approved amendments in the press note (PN) 3 of 2020 under which foreign companies having a Chinese shareholding of up to 10 per cent will be eligible to invest in India under the automatic route across sectors.

However, the relaxed FDI rules will not apply to entities registered in China/Hong Kong or other countries sharing land borders with India.

The government has also decided that FDI proposals in specified sectors/activities of manufacturing in capital goods, electronic capital goods,

The relaxed rules will not apply to entities registered in China/Hong Kong or countries sharing borders with India

electronic components, polysilicon and ingot-wafer or any other sector/activity added by the committee of secretaries headed by the Cabinet Secretary will be processed within 60 days. Though the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) has notified these changes, the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA) has not yet notified them.

“The DEA will have to issue the notification under FEMA (Foreign Exchange Management Act). It will be notified very soon. It requires a lot of fine-tuning,” DPIIT Joint Sec-

retary Jai Prakash Shivahare told reporters here.

He added that the department is working to identify sub-sectors whose applications will be processed within 60 days. Shivahare also informed that total FDI, which includes reinvested earnings, has touched USD 88.29 billion during April-February 2025-26. It was USD 80.61 billion in 2024-25. The net FDI into the country has increased to USD 6.26 billion during April-February 2025-26 against USD 959 million in the full fiscal year of 2024-25.

Meanwhile, addressing the media, DPIIT Secretary Amardeep Singh Bhatia said the total foreign direct investment (FDI) is likely to reach USD 90 billion in the full 2025-26 fiscal.

He said that reform measures, free trade agreements and fast-growing economic growth are helping the country to attract healthy investments.

RBI ups domestic storage of gold by another 104 tonnes

Overall gold holding moved up marginally to 880.52 MT in March

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank has moved another 104.23 metric tonnes of its gold holdings domestically in the six months ended March 2026.

The central bank’s overall gold holding moved up marginally to 880.52 MT in March 2026 from 880.18 MT at the end of September 2025, as per the half-yearly report on the management of foreign exchange reserves shared on Thursday.

The quantum of gold held domestically increased to 290.37 MT in March 2026 from 575.82 MT in September last year and 511.99 MT in March 2025, it said.

The report said 197.67 MT of gold was kept in safe custody with the Bank of England and the Bank for International Settlements (BIS), and 2.80 MT were held in the form of gold deposits as of March 2026.

In September, the central bank had disclosed that 290.37 MT of gold is held with the Bank of England and BIS, while 13.99 MT was in the form of gold deposits.

The rally in the prices of the precious metals led to the share of gold reserves in the forex rising to 16.7 per cent in March from 13.92 per cent six months ago.

Out of the total foreign



The quantum of gold held domestically increased to 290.37 MT in March 2026

currency assets of USD 552.28 billion, USD 465.61 billion was invested in securities, USD 46.83 billion was deposited with other central banks and the BIS, and the balance, USD 39.84 billion, comprised deposits with commercial banks overseas.

There were minor tweaks in the deployment pattern on FCA, with investments in securities and deposits with commercial banks overseas ceding some space in favour of deposits with other central banks and BIS.

The Reserve Bank’s net forward asset (payable) stood at USD 103.06 billion at the end of March 2026, the data showed.

MPOST

Kalpesh Jain appointed SIF Fund Manager at Kotak MF

NEW DELHI: Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company Ltd (KMAMC/Kotak Mutual Fund) has appointed Kalpesh Jain as Fund Manager for its Specialised Investment Funds (SIF) category.

Managing Director Nilesh Shah said the new category offers scope for differentiated strategies backed by strong processes and disciplined risk management, adding that Jain’s experience and risk-aware approach align with the firm’s philosophy.

Jain said he looks forward to strengthening Kotak’s specialised investment capabilities through a research-driven approach focused on prudent risk management and long-term capital growth. He brings over 18 years of experience across fund management, wealth advisory and capital markets.

MPOST

UPI transaction value exceeds Rs 314 lakh crore in FY 2025-26

NEW DELHI: Unified Payments Interface (UPI), which completed 10 years of operations, has reached a record Rs 314 lakh crore in transaction value in FY26, representing more than a 4,000-fold increase since inception.

The transaction value was just Rs 0.07 lakh crore in 2016-17, the first year of UPI operation. UPI, launched on April 11, 2016, by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) under the regulatory oversight of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), has emerged as the backbone of India’s digital payments ecosystem and a critical driver of financial inclusion, the finance ministry said in a statement.

“Over a decade of operations, UPI has demonstrated extraordinary scale and momentum. Annual transaction volume expanded from just 2 crore transactions in FY 2016-17 to over 24,162 crore transactions in FY 2025-26,

representing an almost 12,000-fold surge in transaction volume,” it said.

This simultaneous expansion in both volume and value highlights UPI’s deepening role in supporting high-frequency retail payments, it said.

The Year 2025 marked a significant milestone in the growth trajectory of the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), it said. Monthly transaction volumes crossed 2,000 crore transactions for the first time in August 2025, reaching 2,001 crore transactions, signalling a new scale of adoption, it said.

This momentum continued through the remainder of the year, with December 2025 recording 2,163 crore transactions, the highest monthly transaction volume in UPI’s decade-long journey, it said.

Over the course of the calendar year 2025, it said, UPI processed approximately 22,000 crore transactions in total, translating into a daily

average of about 60 crore transactions. This sustained high-frequency usage reflects the deep penetration of digital payments across the country and the growing trust of citizens, merchants, and businesses in India’s digital payments ecosystem, it said.

UPI has witnessed a steady and broad-based expansion in institutional participation since its launch. “The number of banks live on UPI increased from 44 banks in FY 2016-17, the first year of operations, to 703 banks by FY 2025-26. This onboarding covers public sector banks, private banks, small finance banks, payment banks, and cooperative banks, enabling UPI’s deep geographic reach,” it said.

Each bank functions as a Remitter PSP (processing outgoing transactions) and/or a Beneficiary PSP (receiving funds), with NPCI monitoring performance metrics for all participants, it said.

MPOST

EYES €2 BILLION EXPORTS BY 2030

Renault Group moves NCLT for India operations overhaul

RAJEEV NARAYAN

NEW DELHI: Renault Group has approached the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) seeking approval for a proposed restructuring of its India operations, in a move that signals a sharper and focused business strategy for the country.

According to the company, the restructuring plan envisages a clearer segregation of

operational functions. Powertrain manufacturing will be placed under a dedicated, separate entity, while vehicle manufacturing and sales operations will be brought together under a unified and integrated structure. The realignment is aimed at ensuring that operational frameworks are suited to the distinct technical and commercial requirements of each business vertical.

The proposed overhaul

‘The proposed overhaul forms part of Renault’s long-term strategy to strengthen its India foothold’

forms part of Renault’s long-term strategy to strengthen its India foothold and enhance the country’s significance in its

global operations. As part of this, the company is positioning India as a key manufacturing and export hub, targeting exports of up to €2 billion annually by 2030.

Renault says the restructuring exercise is not expected to disrupt ongoing operations, adding that there will be no adverse impact on employees, customers, dealers, suppliers or other stakeholders. Existing employment terms,

service continuity and business relationships will remain unchanged, with all commitments across manufacturing, supply chains and services continuing without interruption.

The development comes amid a wider recalibration of Renault’s India strategy, following recent structural shifts, including the company acquiring full control of its Chennai-based manufacturing operations. At the same time,

the automaker is gearing up for a renewed product push, with an increased emphasis on higher-value vehicles and electrified powertrain technologies.

With India assuming growing importance in its global ambitions, Renault’s latest move underscores its intent to build a more agile, export-oriented and future-ready business in one of the world’s most competitive automotive markets.

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: The free trade agreements (FTAs) finalised by India in the last three and a half years will help provide duty-free access to domestic goods, boost the country’s exports and generate lakhs of jobs for people, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday.

He said that India and New Zealand have recently signed a trade pact, under which the island nation will invest USD 20 billion (about Rs 2 lakh crore) in India.

“We are opening new markets for the Indian industry and taking steps to support them ... we have finalised nine FTAs in the last three and a half years ... recently we have signed with New Zealand ... it will help create jobs for lakhs of people,” Goyal told reporters here.

India and New Zealand on March 27 inked a ‘once-in-a-generation’ trade pact, giving duty-free access to 100 per cent of domestic exports, including textiles, leather footwear,

INSIGHT

» He said that India and New Zealand have recently signed a trade pact, under which the island nation will invest USD 20 billion in India

» The pact is expected to be implemented by the end of this year as it requires New Zealand Parliament’s approval

and gems and jewellery, in the island nation.

The pact is expected to be implemented by the end of this year as it requires New Zealand Parliament’s approval. In India, the Union cabinet approves a trade pact.

For the second time in a trade deal, India has received an FDI (foreign direct investment) commitment of USD 20 billion over 15 years. A similar commitment of USD 100 billion was made by four-European nation bloc EFTA in its pact with India.

HFCL reports ‘best-ever’ results; PAT jumps 90%

NEW DELHI: HFCL Ltd on Thursday reported record financial performance for FY26, with revenue rising 21.77 per cent year-on-year to Rs 4,949.27 crore, driven by strong execution and an improved business mix. EBITDA surged 63 per cent to Rs 826.75 crore, while profit after tax jumped 90 per cent to Rs 329.44 crore, reflecting significant margin expansion.

The company also posted its highest-ever quarterly performance, with revenue soaring 128 per cent year-on-year to Rs 1,824 crore. Export revenue rose sharply to Rs 2,047 crore, accounting for 41 per cent of total revenue, highlighting its growing global footprint.

HFCL’s order book reached a record Rs 21,206 crore, ensuring strong multi-year revenue visibility. It has recommended a 20 per cent dividend.

Managing Director Mahendra Nahata said FY26 marked a defining year, with defence and aerospace emerging as key growth drivers for the company’s next phase.

MPOST

India’s marine fish catch rises 3% in 2025; Kerala records 2% growth: ICAR-CMFRI

‘Tamil Nadu emerges as the top marine fish-producing state, overtaking Gujarat’

MPOST BUREAU

KOCHI: India’s marine fish production in 2025 rose by 3 per cent to 35.7 lakh tonnes compared to the previous year, ICAR-CMFRI on Thursday said.

According to an assessment by the ICAR-Central Marine Fisheries Research Institute (CMFRI), Tamil Nadu emerged as the top marine fish-producing state, overtaking Gujarat with 6.85 lakh tonnes.

A CMFRI statement said Gujarat slipped to second place after a 15 per cent decline, attributed to adverse weather, extended fishing bans, and cyclonic disturbances.

Kerala remained in third position with marine fish landings of 6.24 lakh tonnes, registering a marginal 2 per cent increase over 2024.

Among other major states, Karnataka recorded a 44 per cent surge in landings following a steep decline in 2024, while Maharashtra posted an 18 per cent increase.



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

As per CMFRI’s annual marine fish landing estimates, Indian mackerel remained the most landed marine resource in the country at 2.70 lakh tonnes, followed by cephalopods at 2.57 lakh tonnes and oil sardine at 2.53 lakh tonnes.

“Cephalopods and threadfin breams recorded growth of 25 per cent and 55 per cent respectively, both reaching decadal-high levels. Pelagic fish accounted for 54 per cent of the total catch, followed by demersal resources, crustaceans and molluscs, the statement said.

In Kerala, Indian oil sar-

dine emerged as the top marine resource with landings of 1.68 lakh tonnes, up 13 per cent over 2024 and marking a decadal high.

Threadfin breams and cephalopods in the state registered increases of 27 per cent and 16 per cent respectively.

Kerala accounted for around 17 per cent of India’s total marine fish production in 2025, CMFRI said.

“Heavy rain and a cargo shipwreck led to the loss of fishing days in May and June in the southern districts of the state, affecting operations,” it said.

CLOSER LOOK

» Gujarat slipped to second place after a 15% decline, attributed to adverse weather, extended fishing bans, and cyclonic disturbances

» Kerala remained in 3rd position with fish landings of 6.24L lakh tonnes, registering a marginal 2% increase over 2024

Ernakulam district contributed the highest share of Kerala’s marine fish landings at 29 per cent, followed by Kollam at 25 per cent and Kozhikode at 18 per cent.

Among landing centres, Neendakara in Kollam topped the list with around 70,000 tonnes, followed by Munambam with nearly 64,000 tonnes.

“Favourable environmental conditions played a crucial role in supporting the revival of small pelagic fish stocks during the period. This ecological advantage was further reinforced by regulated fish-

PAYMENT TO START AFTER 5 YEARS

Govt slashes Voda Idea AGR dues by about 27% to Rs 64,046 crore

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: In a relief to debt-ridden Vodafone Idea, the government has slashed the adjusted gross revenue liability of the telecom company by about 27 per cent to Rs 64,046 crore after reassessing statutory dues, and has allowed a five-year moratorium on these payments.

The Department of Telecom (DoT) had formed a committee to reassess the adjusted gross revenue (AGR), which was fixed at Rs 87,695 crore as of December 31, 2025. The final amount, however, was subject to reassessment by the DoT and final approval by the committee.

Vodafone Idea, in an exchange filing on Thursday, said: "The DoT ... has informed that the Committee formed for the purpose has finalised the AGR dues at Rs 64,046 crore as



HIGHLIGHTS

- » The DoT had formed a committee to reassess the AGR, which was fixed at Rs 87,695 cr as of December 31, 2025
- » The final amount, however, was subject to reassessment by the DoT and the panel's approval
- » VI has to clear final dues in two sets spread over 10 years

on 31 December 2025."

The company has to clear final dues in two sets spread over ten years, and the first payment is due after five years. It will need to pay a minimum of Rs 100 crore annually over four years from FY 2031-32 to FY 2034-35 and the remaining amount in six equal instalments annually from FY 2035-36 to FY 2040-41, the filing said. The company, however, has to make an annual payment of Rs 124

crore towards AGR dues pertaining to FY2018 and FY2019 from March 2026 to March 2031. These dues were not part of the reassessment.

Following reassessment, Vi has to pay a minimum of Rs 100 annually over four years between March' 2032 and March' 2035. The remaining AGR dues have to be paid in equal instalments annually over six years, i.e. between March'36 and March'41 which will be Rs.

10,608 crore annually.

The Union Cabinet on December 31 approved a major relief package for Vodafone Idea, freezing its outstanding AGR dues and granting a five-year moratorium on payment in a move to provide a critical lifeline to the beleaguered telco.

The move followed a favourable order VIL got from the Supreme Court, which allowed the government to reconsider and take an appropriate deci-

sion with reference to the additional AGR demand raised for the period up to the financial year 2016-2017, and to comprehensively reassess and reconcile all AGR (adjusted gross revenue) dues, including interest and penalty.

The relief measures approved by the Union Cabinet aim to protect the interest of the government (which has about 48.9 per cent stake in the telco), enable orderly payment of dues to the Centre by way of spectrum auction charges and AGR dues, ensure competition in the sector and safeguard the interests of around 20 crore consumers of Vodafone Idea.

AGR dues refer to payments owed by telecom companies to the government based on Adjusted Gross Revenue (AGR). It is the revenue on which telecom operators must pay license fees and spectrum usage charges.

'Fertiliser output steady despite Middle East crisis'

Government secures 37 lakh ton urea imports for kharif

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government on Thursday said domestic urea production has reached 37.49 lakh tonnes in March-April, nearly matching last year's levels despite the West Asia crisis, while securing 37 lakh tonnes of imported urea to meet the shortfall ahead of the Kharif season.

Total domestic fertiliser production stood at 62.37 lakh tonnes during March-April, while imports were at 15.39 lakh tonnes.

"The domestic production and import of fertilisers after the crisis have been strong as ever ... approximately 78 lakh tonne of fertilisers has been added to availability in the crisis situation," said Aparna S Sharma at the inter-ministerial briefing on developments in West Asia.

India produced 16.49 lakh tonnes of urea in March and 21 lakh tonnes in April, taking



Total domestic fertiliser production stood at 62.37L tonnes during Mar-Apr

the total to 37.49 lakh tonnes. "It was almost the same during the same period last year, and we have reached that level," Sharma said. The urea shortfall is being met through imports.

"We floated a global tender and secured about 37 lakh tonnes of urea to meet the shortfall," she added.

Domestic production of Diammonium Phosphate (DAP) reached 4.79 lakh tonnes, NPK at 12.69 lakh tonnes and Single

Super Phosphate (SSP) at 7.40 lakh tonnes during the March-April period. A global tender for phosphatic fertilisers has also been floated for 19 lakh tonnes, and the availability of fertiliser raw materials is being regularly reviewed at all levels.

"Fertiliser availability remains robust as ever and supplies continue to exceed requirement," Sharma said.

For Kharif 2026, against a requirement of 390.45 lakh tonnes, current stocks stand at 193.38 lakh tonnes — approximately 50 per cent of the total requirement. Urea availability is at 73.81 lakh tonnes, DAP at 23.47 lakh tonnes, with other fertilisers also well-stocked.

"This reflects improved planning, advanced stocking and efficient logistics managed by the government. The supply position continues to be strong in the states," Sharma said, adding that there has been no change in the maximum retail price (MRP) of fertilisers.

Registrations of properties in Mumbai rise 9% in Apr: Report

NEW DELHI: The registration of properties in the Mumbai municipal region rose 9 per cent to 14,228 units during April, a 14-year high for the month, according to Knight Frank.

As many as 13,080 properties were registered in April 2025 and 15,983 units in March 2026. In a statement on Thursday, real estate consultant Knight Frank India said the registration of properties in Mumbai city (area under BMC jurisdiction) stood at a record 14,228 units till 8.15 pm of April, as per the data compiled from the Maharashtra Department of Registrations and Stamps. The data relates to transactions from both the primary and secondary real estate markets. "Property registrations in April 2026 mark the highest volume for the month of April in the past 14 years, surpass-

As many as 13,080 properties were registered in April 2025 and 15,983 units in March 2026

ing the previous peak recorded in April 2025, highlighting the resilience of Mumbai's residential market," it added.

Shishir Bajjal, International Partner, Chairman & Managing Director, Knight Frank India, said, "Mumbai's residential market continues to demonstrate resilient momentum, with April 2026 registering the strongest performance for any April in over a decade".

This sustained growth in registrations underscores enduring end-user confidence, even on a high base, he added.

SC slams govt for not filing affidavit on plea to control unpredictable fluctuations in airfares

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday pulled up the Centre for not filing its affidavit on a petition which sought regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta asked the Centre to file an application along with an affidavit giving reasons for why the affidavit has not been filed and why further time was sought for it.

On November 17 last year, the top court sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea by social activist S Laxminarayana, who sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector.

As soon as the hearing commenced on Thursday, the counsel appearing for the petitioner said no reply has been filed by the Centre yet. The Centre's counsel referred to the evolu-



The bench refused to grant 3 weeks time and said the affidavit be filed next week

tion situation in the Middle East.

"What is this? What prevents you from filing an affidavit," the bench asked.

The Centre's counsel said they were contemplating framing rules. "You file an affidavit and place everything on record. Why can't you file an affidavit? What is this stand of the Union? Three times we have granted you time," the bench said. The Centre's counsel requested that

three weeks time be granted to file the affidavit.

The bench refused to grant three weeks time and said the affidavit be filed next week.

"You file your affidavit and say whatever you want to say. Your affidavit must come by next Friday (May 8)," the bench said. In its order, the bench said despite the fact that notice was issued on the petition on November 17 last year and thereafter time was granted to the respondents to file the affidavit, "till date no affidavit has been filed". It said today also the counsel representing the Centre has sought some more time.

"We are not willing to accept the request. Let an appropriate application along with an affidavit giving reasons for why affidavit has not been filed and why further time is being sought, be filed within a week. List again on May 11," the bench said. On February 23, the Centre told the apex court that the Ministry of Civil Aviation was actively

considering the issues raised in the plea.

While hearing the matter on January 19, the top court said it would interfere with the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfares and flagged the exorbitant rise during festivals.

The top court had termed the exorbitant rise of airfares by the airlines as "exploitation" and asked the Centre and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to file their replies on the plea. In November last year, it had issued notices to the Centre, the DGCA and the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India seeking their responses on the plea.

The plea claimed that all private airlines have, without any credible justification, reduced the free check-in baggage allowance for economy class passengers from 25 kg to 15 kg, "thereby converting what was earlier part of the ticketed service into a new revenue stream".

PSU banks recruit 50,552 candidates in FY26, 33% higher than FY25

NEW DELHI: Public sector banks (PSBs) have recruited a total of 50,552 candidates in FY2025-26, 33 per cent higher than the previous year, the finance ministry said on Thursday. This represents a significant augmentation of manpower to meet the growing business requirements of the banking sector, the ministry said in a statement.

This builds on the trend observed in preceding years, wherein the data stood at 30,827 in 2023-24 and increased to 37,860 in 2024-25, reflecting a clear and sus-

tained year-on-year expansion in workforce across PSBs and a planned approach towards ensuring adequate staffing across PSB offices, it said.

Recruitment in PSBs is conducted through the Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS), in accordance with the specific manpower requirements of participating banks, it said. This centralised and standardised framework ensures transparency and efficiency in the selection process, it said.

The Government remains committed to ensuring that PSBs are equipped with ade-

quate, skilled, and future-ready human resources, enabling them to play a pivotal role in driving financial inclusion, supporting economic activity, and meeting the economy's evolving needs, it said.

In a separate statement, the ministry said, National Asset Reconstruction Company Limited (NARCL) has emerged as a cornerstone of India's stressed asset resolution architecture, playing an important role in supporting the banking sector's balance sheet strengthening.

By bringing together large stressed exposures and facili-

tating their resolution through transparent and market-based mechanisms, NARCL has contributed to improving recovery outcomes and unlocking value for lenders, it said.

As on March 2026, NARCL has acquired 33 borrower entities with an aggregate debt exposure of Rs 1,65,862 crore, it said, adding, it has also participated in resolution processes under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, further strengthening its role in the overall resolution ecosystem.

FY 2025-26 marks a significant acceleration in NAR-

CL's recovery efforts, with Rs 4,364 crore realised during the year, accounting for approximately 70 per cent of cumulative recoveries.

"This momentum underscores the effectiveness of ongoing resolution strategies. Recoveries have been effected in 23 accounts, with total recoveries of Rs 6,345 crore, representing more than 48 per cent of acquisition cost, and further recoveries are underway," it said.

Importantly, three accounts have been fully resolved, delivering recovery of 148 per cent,

115 per cent and 183 per cent, demonstrating value maximisation and positive outcomes for lenders, it said.

Building on this momentum, it said, NARCL continues to advance its resolution efforts, including evaluation and acquisition of additional large-value accounts.

The company remains on track to achieve its targeted acquisition of Rs 2 lakh crore, reinforcing its role in enabling capital recycling, improving balance sheet strength of banks, and supporting sustained credit growth in the economy.

Bank credit to industry grows at healthy pace of 15% in Mar: RBI data

MUMBAI: Bank credit to industry clocked a faster yearly growth of 15 per cent in March, mainly driven by a consistent uptick in advances to large companies, according to the Reserve Bank data released on Thursday.

The RBI has released data on 'sectoral deployment of bank credit' for March, collected from 41 select banks, which together account for about 95 per cent of the total non-food credit by all scheduled commercial banks (SCBs).

On a year-on-year basis, non-food bank credit grew by 15.9 per cent as of the fortnight ended March 31, 2026, compared to 10.9 per cent during the corresponding period of the previous year (April 04, 2025), it said.

"Credit to industry recorded a y-o-y growth of 15 per cent (8.2 per cent in the corresponding fortnight of the last year)," the RBI said.

Bank loans to micro, small and medium industries sustained robust expansion, while credit to large industries also strengthened further. Among major industries, outstanding

Bank loans to micro, small and medium industries sustained robust expansion, while credit to large industries also strengthened further

credit to 'infrastructure', 'all engineering', 'basic metal and metal product', 'chemical and chemical products', and 'petroleum, coal products and nuclear fuels' marked resilient annual growth, the central bank said.

Further, credit to agriculture and allied activities registered a year-on-year growth of 15.7 per cent compared to 10.4 per cent in the corresponding fortnight of the previous year.

RBI data also showed that credit to the services sector registered a growth rate of 19 per cent (12 per cent in the corresponding fortnight of the previous year), supported by higher growth in segments, such as 'non-banking financial companies', 'trade' and 'commercial real estate'.

Trai begins exploring spectrum allocation, pricing norms for wireless communication from vehicles

Move would pave the way for introduction of autonomous or self-driven cars in India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Telecom regulator Trai on Thursday floated a consultation paper to explore spectrum allocation and pricing norms for wireless communication from vehicles-- a move that will pave the way for the introduction of autonomous or self-driven cars in India.

The Department of Telecom (DoT) has asked the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) to provide suggestions on a regulatory mechanism comprising spectrum assignment, authorization and pricing for roadside units that will be put in place as part of proposed intelligent transport system as well as any other relevant recommendation on the subject.

"A consultation paper on the Regulatory Framework for Vehicle-to-Everything (V2X) Communication has been placed on Trai's website. Written comments on the issues raised in the consultation paper are invited from stakeholders by May 28, 2026 and



counter-comments by June 11, 2026," Trai said.

DoT, telecom industry body COAI, Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI), chip company Qualcomm, technology firm Idemia, etc., are part of the task force constituted by Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) for implementation of Intelligent Transportation Systems (ITS)

in the country, with specific focus on Vehicle to Everything (V2X). "V2X enables vehicles to wirelessly exchange real-time information with every relevant element of their environment. This includes other vehicles (V2V), roadside infrastructure such as traffic signals and toll booths (V2I), vulnerable road users like pedestrians and cyclists (V2P), and the broader cellular network (V2N)," Trai said.

CLOSER LOOK

» The DoT has asked the Trai to provide suggestions on a regulatory mechanism comprising spectrum assignment, authorisation and pricing for roadside units that will be put in place as part of proposed intelligent transport system

» DoT, COAI, SIAM, ARAI, Qualcomm, Idemia, etc, are part of the task force constituted by MoRTH for implementation of Intelligent Transportation Systems

The DoT has already agreed to provide 30 MHz spectrum (5875-5905 MHz) for the initial deployment of C-V2X (cellular-V2X) technology, while the remaining 20 MHz (5905-5925 MHz) may be reserved for future ITS applications.

The rollout of the intelligent transport system (ITS) is also expected to reduce road accidents, improve traffic management, optimise infrastructure etc.

According to data published by Trai, approximately 92 per cent of road accidents are often attributed to failures in human recognition like driver disregard, insufficient surveillance, drivers' distraction and human decision mistakes such as too fast driving, delayed reactions, and misjudging of the safety distance.

The paper said that even with the development of various safety-oriented techniques in vehicles, such as anti-locking braking systems (ABS), seatbelts, airbags, and rear-view cameras etc., many people die annually from road traffic accidents.

"By allowing vehicles to exchange real-time information, such as location, speed, and status, C-V2X (cellular-V2X) enables advanced safety applications like collision avoidance, intersection management, and emergency vehicle warning systems. This technology has the potential to greatly reduce accidents, injuries, and fatalities on the road," Trai said.

FinMin to banks: Adopt MuleHunter AI tool of RBI

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju on Thursday asked banks to adopt the MuleHunter AI tool developed by RBI at the earliest for timely identification and prevention of mule accounts involved in financial cyber frauds.

During a meeting with senior officials of law enforcement agency, RBI and banks, he reviewed the digital financial frauds and increasing use of mule accounts by the cyber criminals.

During the meeting he also advised State Level Bankers' Committee to sensitise the State Police Authorities about the steps taken by the banks for prevention of cyber financial frauds and undertake greater public awareness initiatives, the Department of Financial Services said in a post on X.

The discussion focused on 'Operation Octopus' recently carried out by the Hyderabad Police, and learnings emerged from it, it said.

GUJARAT ENDED UP AT 158 FOR SIX IN 15.5 OVERS

Holder, Gill power GT to 4-wicket win over RCB

Massive win, says Buttler after GT's victory

AHMEDABAD: Jason Holder was immense on the night, taking two wickets and three catches. Shubman Gill and Jos Buttler then backed his all-round prowess with handy cameos as Gujarat Titans sealed a nervy four-wicket win over Royal Challengers Bengaluru in an IPL match here on Thursday.

Holder's two-wicket burst (2/29) and those sharp catches helped the Titans bowl out defending champions RCB for a modest 155 in 19.2 overs. But with Gill (43, 18b), Buttler (39, 19) and later Rahul Tewatia (27 not out, 17b) leading the charge, GT ended up at 158 for six in 15.5 overs.

RCB remained second in the table with 12 points, and GT too was static on fifth but added two valuable points to swell their tally to 10 after this game.

After the early departure of Sai Sudharsan, the Titans' charge to victory started with Gill's uncharacteristically aggressive knock of 43 off 18 balls (4x4, 3x6).

Taking on the new-ball attack, Gill hammered Bhuvneshwar Kumar for a four and a six before going after Josh Hazlewood, tearing into



Gujarat Titans' captain Shubman Gill (front right), being congratulated by RCB's Virat Kohli and others after winning IPL match, in Ahmedabad on Thursday PTI

the Australian with three fours and two sixes in a 24-run over as GT raced to 36 without loss

in just two overs. On the other hand, Buttler, who was dropped on 1

by stumper Jitesh Sharma off Hazlewood, made RCB pay instantly. He scooped the very

next ball cleanly for a six over fine leg and never looked back. Buttler finished the pow-

17
RCB remained second in the table with 12 points, and GT too was static on fifth but added two valuable points to swell their tally to 10 after this game

erplay in style with a four and a six as GT surged to 69 for 2.

He continued the charge after the field spread, smashing spinner Suyash Sharma for back-to-back sixes -- one straight down the ground and another sliced over long-off -- in a 17-run over.

But Gill fell to Bhuvneshwar as his powerful punch found Kohli inside the circle. The veteran pacer soon struck to jettison Buttler to cap a fine spell. In the process, Bhuvneshwar reached 352 wickets, becoming

only the second Indian bowler after Yuzvendra Chahal (391) to cross the 350-wicket mark in T20s.

Walking in at 111 for five in 10.3 overs, Holder gave a semblance of stability, launching a first-ball six off compatriot Romario Shepherd.

With the required rate never climbing beyond four an over, Holder and Tewatia kept it simple, before the Windies all-rounder got out for 12.

But Tewatia held his nerves to seal the chase as GT registered back-to-back wins.

Earlier, returning to the venue where they had lifted the title last season, RCB were cruising at a run rate in excess of 10 with Kohli leading the charge, smashing Kagiso Rabada for 21 runs in his opening over which included five fours in a row.

But Gill persisted with his strike bowler and the call paid off handsomely.

Rabada (1/38) struck back to remove Kohli for a blazing 28 off 13 balls, triggering a collapse as RCB lost wickets in a cluster through the middle phase.

Left-arm pacer Arshad Khan wrapped the tail and returned with 3/22. AGENCIES

Alcaraz watches brother Jaime win his under-16 debut at Madrid Open

MADRID: Carlos Alcaraz was back at the Madrid Open on Thursday, this time as a spectator to watch younger brother Jaime compete in an under-16 tournament.

Alcaraz, who holds the Australian, French and U.S. Open titles, was in the stands at Court 7 as Jaime Alcaraz defeated fellow Spaniard Pol Mas 6-3, 6-3. Other rela-

tives were on hand as well to watch the tournament debut of 14-year-old Jaime. Among

the Spaniards who have played the under-16 tournament at the Caja Magica in the past were promising stars Martin Landaluce, Daniel Merida and Rafael Jodar.

Carlos Alcaraz withdrew from the Madrid Open because of a right wrist injury. He won't be defending his French Open title in three weeks. AGENCIES

Parag fined 25% of match fees for vaping incident

NEW DELHI: Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag was on Thursday fined 25 per cent of his match fee for bringing the game into "disrepute" after being caught vaping on camera during the IPL game against Punjab Kings in Mullanpur.

Parag's actions during the Royals' chase on Tuesday night drew condemnation on social media.

PTI has learned that on field umpires Tanmay Srivastava and Nitin Menon had not reported the matter to match



RR's captain Riyan Parag takes a catch during match PTI

referee Amit Sharma right after

the game.

They only did that after seeing visual proof and Sharma found Parag guilty for a code of conduct breach as per the IPL guidelines.

The Level 1 offence carries 25 per cent deduction from match fees and one demerit point.

"Riyan admitted to the offence and accepted the sanction imposed by the Match Referee, Amit Sharma," said the IPL in a statement.

"The BCCI is also

exploring other options to initiate proceedings for stringent action against the erring team, its officials and players to ensure that the reputation of IPL remains intact," the statement added.

When PTI reached out to BCCI secretary Devajit Saika on possible action on Rajasthan Royals, he said:

"As it is written clearly in the statement, we are exploring what action to take on the team. It is not decided yet." AGENCIES

Starc boost for DC against high flying RR

Delhi's bowlers couldn't do much while defending 75 in the previous game, but they will need to be sharper against a strong Rajasthan batting line-up

JAIPUR: Delhi Capitals have little time to dwell on what has been a bruising stretch of results as they gear up to face a confident Rajasthan Royals in their Indian Premier League match here on Friday.

It has been a difficult run for the Axar Patel-led side this season. They have swung between extremes in the last two games. From posting a 250-plus total only to concede a world-record chase, to being bowled out for 75 against Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

Add to that a one-run defeat against Gujarat Titans earlier this month, and Delhi have had their share of emotionally damaging results. With three wins and four losses, they are seventh on the table and need a turnaround soon.

Delhi's biggest concern has been their inconsistent batting. While the likes of KL Rahul, David Miller, Tristan Stubbs



It has been a difficult run for the Axar Patel-led side this season

SQUADS

Rajasthan Royals: Shubham Dubey, Shimron Hetmyer, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Dhruv Jurel, Lhuan-dre Pretorius, Riyan Parag (c), Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Donovan Ferreira, Ravindra Jadeja, Jofra Archer, Nandre Burger, Tushar Deshpande, Kwen Maphaka, Sandeep Sharma, Yuvvir Singh Charak, Ravi Bishnoi, Aman Rao Perala, Adam Milne, Kuldeep Sen, Dasun Shanaka, Sushant Mishra, Vignesh Puthur, Ravi Singh, Brijesh Sharma.

Delhi Capitals: Axar Patel (c), K.L. Rahul, Karun Nair, David Miller, Pathum Nissanka, Sahil Parakh, Prithvi Shaw, Abhishek Porel, Tristan Stubbs, Sameer Rizvi, Ashutosh Sharma, Vipraj Nigam, Ajay Mandal, Tripurana Vijay, Madhav Tiwari, Aaquib Dar, Nitish Rana, T. Natarajan, Mukesh Kumar, Dushmantha Chameera, Lungisani Ngidi, Kyle Jamieson, Kuldeep Yadav, Mitchell Starc.

and Sameer Rizvi have all contributed in patches, the unit has failed to click collectively.

In the last match, Abhishek Porel's knock as an Impact Player was one of the few pos-

itives, helping the team avoid a record-low total and the team management will be tempted to give him a go in the playing XI. There is some good news on the bowling front. Pace ace Mitchell Starc is set to return after getting clearance from Cricket Australia to play from May 1. With Lungi Ngidi still unavailable, Starc's inclusion comes as a timely boost. He is likely to replace either Kyle Jamieson or Dushmantha Chameera.

Delhi's bowlers couldn't do much while defending 75 in the previous game, but they will need to be sharper against a strong Rajasthan batting line-up.

Their top order has been aggressive, with fearless Vaibhav Sooryavanshi taking on world class bowlers like Jasprit Bumrah, Josh Hazlewood and Pat Cummins from the outset and Yashasvi Jaiswal showing good touch.

The fourth-placed Royals, in contrast, come into this match with confidence. They recently handed Punjab Kings their first defeat of the season, which was their sixth win in nine games. AGENCIES

THOMAS CUP FINALS

India take on Chinese Taipei in QFs, look to stay on course for title

HORSENS: India will aim to stay on course for a second title when they face a formidable Chinese Taipei in the quarterfinals of the Thomas Cup Finals here on Friday.

Four years ago, India achieved an unprecedented feat by clinching the Thomas Cup crown -- the world team championship of badminton -- bringing the sport firmly into focus among the country's youth.

This time, India progressed to the quarterfinals after finishing second in Group A and will face Chinese Taipei, who are yet to win the title.

India made a strong start to their campaign with a 4-1 win over Canada, followed



HS Prannoy in action

by a 5-0 sweep of Australia, before going down 2-3 to China despite a spirited effort.

Chinese Taipei, who topped Group C, is also a formidable side, led by world No. 6 Chou Tien Chen.

Alongside him, world No.

8 and reigning All England champion Lin Chun-Yi and world No. 21 Chi Yu Jen add depth to their singles line-up.

Chun-Yi, currently one of the most attacking players, had defeated Lakshya in last month's All England Championships summit clash.

They also have Chia Hao Lee, the 2025 All England runner-up, in their ranks. In doubles, the Taiwanese side boasts of the world No. 14 pair of Chiu Hsiang Chieh and Wang Chi-Lin, and world No. 16 duo of Lee Jhe-Huei and Yang Po-Hsuan.

In two matches, Liu Kuang Heng has paired up with Yang Po Han when they faced Denmark and Sweden. AGENCIES

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform public in general that Kotak Mahindra bank Ltd has organized an auction in below mention respect of Vehicles.

- VEHICLES FOR SALE**
- 1) TATA MOTORS TATA_INTRA REG. NO. DL1LAQ8941-YOM-2025
 - 2) TATA MOTORS TATA_INTRA REG. NO. DL1LAL4224-YOM-2023
 - 3) MAH MHMAXXCITY REG. NO. UP14NT6283-YOM-2023
 - 4) TATA MOTORS TLP1912G REG. NO. HR38AH6046-YOM-2024
 - 5) TATA MOTORS TACEGOLD REG. NO. DL1LAH5545-YOM-2022
 - 6) TATA LPT709CH REG. NO. DL1LAG7922-YOM-2022
 - 7) TATA MOTORS TACEGOLCNG REG. NO. DL1LAM2442-YOM-2024
 - 8) EICHR_VECV PRO2114CBC REG. NO. HR55AL9059-YOM-2021
 - 9) TATA MOTORS TACEGOLCNG REG. NO. DL1LAQ2058-YOM-NA
 - 10) TATA MOTORS T_INTRAV20 REG. NO. DL1LAN8440-YOM-NA
 - 11) MARUTIS MAR_BNLNXI REG. NO. HR87Q6236-YOM-NA
 - 12) TATA MOTORS TACEGOLD REG. NO. DL1LAM4394-YOM-2024
 - 13) TATA MOTORS T_INTRAV20 REG. NO. DL1LAM6884-YOM-2024
 - 14) TATA MOTORS TSIGNA5530 REG. NO. HR58D5038-YOM-2024
 - 15) TATA MOTORS TATA_1512 REG. NO. HR38AE5289-YOM-2023
 - 16) JCB JCB3DX REG. NO. UP16FT4670-YOM-2018
 - 17) EICHR_VECV_E_1095EHS REG. NO. DL1MA1632-YOM-2018
 - 18) TATA MOTORS TSIGNA5530 REG. NO. HR58D3551-YOM-2023
 - 19) TATA MOTORS T_INTRAV20 REG. NO. DL1LAL9812-YOM-2023
 - 20) TATA MOTORS TLP7709HSD REG. NO. UP14RT6619-YOM-NA
- UNDER HYPOTHECATION WITH M/S KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK IS UNDER SALE IN ITS "AS IS WHERE IS CONDITION" INTERESTED PARTIES CAN GIVE THEIR QUOTATIONS WITH IN 7 DAYS AT
- BRANCH ADDRESS: KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK 3RD FLOOR, PLOT NO. 7, SECTOR 125, NOIDA-201313 OR CONTACT : RAMAN AHUJA KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK LTD. CONTACT NO. 8377988238 EMAIL-raman.ahuja@kotak.com

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Prakash S/o Ram Bahadur, R/o A-24, Budh Vihar, Munirka, R.K. Puram, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 21367/2020 U/s 379/411/34 IPC Act at P.S. Okhla Industrial Area, South-East District, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrants of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Prakash** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Prakash** have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Prakash** of **FIR No. 21367/2020 U/s 379/411/34 IPC Act at P.S. Okhla Industrial Area, South-East District, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.06.2026**.

By order
Akansha Gautam
Judicial Magistrate-02 First Class,
South East, Room No. 513,
Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

DP/5649/SE/2026

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, **Manisha Sharma** w/o Ritu Raj, R/o 291/16, Near Nanak Dairy, Quilla Mohalla, Bahadurgarh, Distt Jhajjar, Haryana, That the my name mentioned in my above adhar card **Manisha Sharma** but in my education documents (Mark sheets) my name is mentioned as **Manisha Kumari Sharma**. That **Manisha Sharma** and **Manisha Kumari Sharma** is the name of same person i.e. my name.

BSES

BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE

Date: 01.05.2026

Sealed tenders under a single-part (unpriced) bid are invited for services under the Electrical, Civil, IT, and Adminal categories from all eligible vendor:-

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/AL/1356	NEW CONTRACTOR REGISTRATION AND REVALIDATION OF EXISTING CONTRACTORS FOR SERVICES	NA	NA	21.05.2026 15:30 HRS	21.05.2026 16:00 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/-

For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submission of tender documents etc. please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd. Off.: BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527 Telephone No.: +91 11 4910 7235 | Website: www.bsesdelhi.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

Branch Office : ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Parul Soni/ Anubhav Kumar/ H.No. 23-24, Pocket I-3, Ground Floor Sector-16 Rohini Delhi New Delhi Rohini- 110089/ LBGUR00004043879	Flat No D 254, 2nd Floor, Central Park Flower Valley, Situated In Village Dhunela And Berka, Block-D, Sector-29,30,32 And 33, Tehsil- Sohna, Gurgaon, Haryana- 122001	15/04/2026 Rs. 47,49,736/-	22-12-2025
2.	Aashirwad Gaur/ Mohinder Gaur/ H.No.132, Venus Apartment Inder Enclave, Pashchim Vihar West Delhi Delhi Delhi- 110087/ LBDEL00005208632	Apartment No.220, Tower No.J, 2nd Floor, The Room, Central Park Flower Valley, Villages Dhunela & Berka Sector 29, 30 & 32, Tehsil Sohna Gurgaon- 122001	06/04/2026 Rs. 69,29,219.81/-	30-07-2025

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: May 01, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

Bandhan Bank

Regional Office: Netaji Marg, Nr. Mithakhali Six Roads, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-6. Phone: + 91-79-26421671-75

The under mentioned account turned into N.P.A and demand notice is issued by Bandhan Bank Ltd. to the following borrower(s), under sec.13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act (The Act), 2002 which was returned unserved. Hence, this notice is issued to you all and public at large through publication.

Name of borrower(s) and Loan Account No.	Description of mortgaged property (Secured Asset)	Date of Demand Notice/Date of NPA	O/S Amount as on Date of Notice	Date of Posting of Notice
Mr. Sonu Sonu Mrs. Nisha Nisha 2000333000259	All That Piece Or Parcel Of Plot No. 32 & 47, Kharsa No. 12, Killa No. 22/72 & 23, Admeasuring Area 400 Sq. Yds, Waka Muga Nangla, Gujran, Tehsil - Badhalal, Dist. Faridabad, Haryana, 121001. Owned By Mrs. Nisha W/O Mr. Sonu , And Same Bounded As Under: North: Rasta 25 Ft., East: House No. 13 (Plot No. 32 & 47 Part), West: House No. 11 (Plot No. 32 & 47 Part), South: Other Property	February 18, 2026/ April 04, 2024	Rs.22,08,369.85	April 08, 2026

Demand made against you through this notice to repay to the Bank dues mentioned against your name with interest, costs and charges within 60 days from the date hereof, failing which the Bank will further proceed to take steps u/s 13(4) of the SARFAESI Act. The borrowers'/mortgagors' attention is invited to the provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Place: Faridabad
Date: May 01, 2026

Authorised Officer
Bandhan Bank Limited



New Okhla Industrial Development Authority
Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.)
Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

1. Job No. 14/Manager System/Completion AMC-Integration/2025-26, AMC for Online Occupancy/Completion Certificate Software of Noida Properties for one year with manpower support and Integration with Nivesh Mitra 3.0. Cost Rs. 28,45,000/- Exclusive of GST.

Which can be uploaded by date **07.05.2026 upto 5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date **08.05.2026 at 11.00AM**.
Manager (System)

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Akshay Kumar @Golu** S/o Sh. Rana Pratap R/o H. No. RZ-167, J Block, Dharam Pura, Najafgarh, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 794/2023 U/s 25/54/59 ARMS ACT, PS Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Akshay Kumar @Golu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Akshay Kumar @Golu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Akshay Kumar @Golu** in **FIR No. 794/2023 U/s 25/54/59 ARMS ACT, PS Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.06.2026**.

By order
Shri Ankit Karan Singh
Metropolitan Magistrate
Room No. 30
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/5448/OD/2026



UJVNL LIMITED
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Tender Notice

Date: 30/04/2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (Galogi SHP), UJVNL Ltd., Ganga Bhawan, Yamuna Colony, Dehradun, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:

Notice Inviting Tender No: 03/[Galogi SHP]/2026-27: Supply and Installation of 50 kVA Servo Voltage Stabiliser and Associated LT Line Maintenance Works at Bhatta Headworks, Dehradun.

Estimated cost: ₹ 7,65,600.00(GST extra)

Date of availability of bid document on website: 30.04.2026 from 17:00 hrs. **Last date for submission of tender:** 25.05.2026 up to 15:00 hrs.

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website www.ujvnl.com

Executive Engineer (Galogi SHP)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ravi, S/o Sh. Gangaram R/o Vagabond, Patri Andha Mughal, Kishan Ganj, Delhi** Permanent Address **Village Hasanpur, PS & Tehsil Matsena, Firojabad, U.P.** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.519/24 u/s 305(A)/317(2) BNS, P.S. Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ravi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ravi** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ravi of FIR No.519/24 u/s 305(A)/317(2) BNS, P.S. Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.06.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Rangat Ghirra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04 (Central)
Court No.37, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/5610/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Neeraj Dhochak @ Bhura @ Nishu, S/o Rajender Kumar R/o H.No. C-22, Gali No.12, Phase-I, Rishi Nagar, Amar Colony, Nangloi, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.151/2025 dated 29.03.2025 u/s 103(1)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita & 25/27 Arms Act, P.S. Alipur, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Neeraj Dhochak @ Bhura @ Nishu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Neeraj Dhochak @ Bhura @ Nishu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Neeraj Dhochak @ Bhura @ Nishu of FIR No.151/2025 dated 29.03.2025 u/s 103(1)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita & 25/27 Arms Act, P.S. Alipur, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.07.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Priyanka Rajpoot
Ld. Chief Judicial Magistrate, North
Court No.115, 1st Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/5594/ON/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No.: DRMC/AGRA/NFRE-AUCTION Dated :-27.04.2026

E-Auction Notice

On behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per category given as under:-

Category : ADVT Catalogue No.: ADVT-AGRA-AGC-OSN-65-26-2

Asset Details : Commercial publicity via Vinyl wrapping /Board/Paint at Escalator & FOB area of Agra Cant. Railway station Zone IInd.

E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 12.05.2026 Time :- 11:00

E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 12.05.2026 Time :- 11:30

Note : Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 923/26 (D)

North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

N.I.T.No. [02/26-27/WE]

Name of work with its location

(A) Provision of wooden flooring, false ceiling, tiles, doors, painting etc. in rooms/halls at 4th and 5th floor in Rail Bhawan and Renewal of certification (Indian Green Building Council Gold Rating) of Rail Bhawan Building, New Delhi in the section of SSE/W/RB under ADEN/E-III.

Approx. cost of work (A) Rs. 36654172.56

EMD amount (A) Rs. 733100.00

Completion period of work (A) 06 Months

Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender

Closing date of tender on 21.05.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Website particular notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.

Above tender available on website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

No:-128-W/269/O.E./T.NIT No.02/26-27/WE/ Dated:-29.04.2026 1451/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Dharampal, S/o Aasha Ram R/o Village Nawada, PS Katra, Distt. Sahajanpur, UP, Address In Record:- Jhuggi Jailar Wali, Azadpur, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 136/2017, U/s:- 33/38 Delhi Excise Act**, registered at **PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Dharampal**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Dharampal**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Dharampal, FIR No. 136/2017, U/s:- 33/38 Delhi Excise Act**, registered at **PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.07.2026**

By Order
Ms Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-07
Room No-06, First Floor, North District
Rohini Court, Delhi

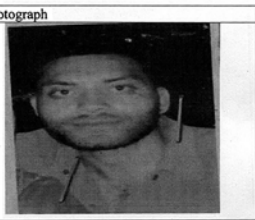
DP/5680/ON/2026

HQ District Police, Kupwara, UT of J&K.

Email: dpkupwara@jkpolice.gov.in Dated: 28/04/2026
NO:- CRB/Lookout Notice/2026/ 24648-99

LOOK OUT NOTICE

As intimated by SHO P/S Karnah vide letter No. 1418/5-A/PSK/2026 dated 28-04-2026, that accused Raja Zahoor Akbar S/O Raja Gh Akbar R/O Teetwal is involved in case FIR No. 17 & 18/2023 U/S 8/21, 29 NDPS Act of P/S Karnah and is absconding after commission of crime. Despite strenuous efforts, whereabouts of the said accused are not ascertained so far. The Photograph alongwith description roll of absconding accused person is as under:

Description Roll	Photograph
Name:- Raja Zahoor Akbar Parentage:- Raja Gh Akbar Address:- Teetwal Karnah Age:- 42 years Height:- 5 Feet 8 Inch Complexion:- whitish Build:- Normal	

It is therefore requested that a sharp lookout may please be maintained and if traced out or any clue leading to the whereabouts of said absconding accused, immediate information may kindly be shared on the below mentioned Email/phone No's.

Email: dpkupwara@jkpolice.gov.in
PCR Kupwara:- 7051404938
SHO P/S Kupwara: 7051404924
PS Kupwara:- 7051404925

Sd/-
Syed Al-Tahir Glani JKPS
Sr. Superintendent of Police,
Kupwara

DIP No:DIP /J-1409/26

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited for execution of the following works by Divisional Railway Manager(Engg.), E.C. Railway, Dhanbad-
S.No.01, E-Tender No. : 21-DHN-2026-27. Name of the work with its location & completion period : Special repairs to staff quarters at PTRU under SSE/Works/PTRU in the jurisdiction of ADEN/BRKA. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. cost of work (In Rs.) : ₹6,60,36,751.43.

S.No.02, E-Tender No. : 22-DHN-2026-27. Name of the work with its location & completion period : Special repairs to staff quarters at BRWD under SSE/Works/BRWD in the jurisdiction of ADEN/DTO. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. cost of work (In Rs.) : ₹4,83,96,028/-

S.No.03, E-Tender No. : 23-DHN-2026-27. Name of the work with its location & completion period : Intensive repair of 326 Railway Quarters with leaky roof treatment and all basic amenities required in the Habitable Residential Quarters in the jurisdiction of SSE/W-2/DHN under ADEN/1/DHN. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. cost of work (In Rs.) : ₹3,30,70,498/-

S.No.04, E-Tender No. : 24-DHN-2026-27. Name of the work with its location & completion period : Intensive repair of 804 Railway Quarters in (Hill) (201), Hospital (142), Rangatand (212), Bekarband (184), D/ing (20), Matkuriay colony (45) = total 804 no., with all basic amenities required in the Habitable Residential Quarters in the jurisdiction of SSE/W-1/DHN under ADEN/1/DHN. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. cost of work (In Rs.) : ₹7,26,39,081/-

S.No.05, E-Tender No. : 25-DHN-2026-27. Name of the work with its location & completion period : Provision of 3.0M wide FOB at CNF & KFT. 18 (Eighteen) Months. Approx. cost of work (In Rs.) : ₹6,88,39,547.75/-

Earnest Money (In Rs.) : Earnest Money is applicable as shown in http://www.ireps.gov.in.portal. Date & Time for closing and opening of e-tender : Date of closing of e-tender at 12.00 hours on 25.05.2026. Date of opening of e-tender from 12.30 hrs. on 25.05.2026. Website particulars : <http://www.ireps.gov.in> No manual tender will be accepted against e-tendering.

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ ECR/Dhanbad
PR/0151/DHN/Engg./T/26-27/68

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA).

A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Sourav, Renu Bala, Naina, 1342/7, Gali Dhana Singh, Chowk Lachmansar, Amritsar, Punjab- 143001, A/c No. LBAMT00005343394	House Bearing Private No. 2-A, Measuring 44.44 Sq. Yards, Comprised In Minjumla Kharsa No. 5/23/1, 5/23/10, 5/23/11, 5/23/12, 5/23/13, 5/23/14, 5/23/15, 5/23/16, 5/23/17, 5/23/18, 5/23/19, 5/23/2, 5/23/3, 5/23/4, 5/23/5, 5/23/6, 5/23/7, 5/23/8, 5/23/9, 12/1/1, 12/1/2, 12/1/3, 12/1/4, 12/1/5, 12/1/6, 12/1/7, 12/1/8, 12/1/9, 12/1/10, 12/1/11, 12/1/12, 12/1/13, 12/1/14, 12/1/15, 12/1/16, 12/1/17, 12/1/18, 12/1/19, 12/1/20, 12/1/21, 12/1/22, 12/1/23, 12/1/24, 12/1/25, 12/1/26, 12/1/27, 12/1/28, 12/1/29, 12/1/30, 12/1/31, 12/1/32, 12/1/33, 12/1/34, 12/1/35, 12/1/36, 12/1/37, 12/1/38, 12/1/39, 12/1/40, 12/1/41, 12/1/42, 12/1/43, 12/1/44, 12/1/45, 12/1/46, 12/1/47, 12/1/48, 12/1/49, 12/1/50, 12/1/51, 12/1/52, 12/1/53, 12/1/54, 12/1/55, 12/1/56, 12/1/57, 12/1/58, 12/1/59, 12/1/60, 12/1/61, 12/1/62, 12/1/63, 12/1/64, 12/1/65, 12/1/66, 12/1/67, 12/1/68, 12/1/69, 12/1/70, 12/1/71, 12/1/72, 12/1/73, 12/1/74, 12/1/75, 12/1/76, 12/1/77, 12/1/78, 12/1/79, 12/1/80, 12/1/81, 12/1/82, 12/1/83, 12/1/84, 12/1/85, 12/1/86, 12/1/87, 12/1/88, 12/1/89, 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Kritika reveals she escaped THE CASTING COUCH

Kamra, who is currently in the news for 'Matka King', opened up about the darker side of her journey in the film industry

Kritika Kamra, who is currently in the news for her show 'Matka King', opened up about the darker side of her journey in the film industry, from a brush with the casting couch to fighting Bollywood's deeply entrenched bias against TV actors. The actress spoke candidly about hierarchy, prejudice and her unwavering commitment to playing women with agency on screen.

Reflecting on her early years in the industry, Kritika didn't shy away from addressing one of Bollywood's most uncomfortable realities: the casting couch. She credited her survival more to luck than to any particular presence of mind. In an interview with 'News18 Showsha', she said, "I had heard about things like the casting couch. My parents had read about it in the papers. I also had a brush with it but got off unscathed. It was just luck and chance. It wasn't because I was too smart. I really wasn't because when I had started out, I was really young."

Despite her growing profile in the streaming space, Kritika said that the stigma of being a TV actor has never fully disappeared. She described Bollywood's unspoken hierarchy in strikingly blunt terms. She said, "I've experienced this hierarchy. I was happily doing TV. In my head, there was no difference between TV and films."

The actress, who recently got married to sports commentator Gaurav Kapur,



added, "I came from a small town and anybody who was onscreen was an actor for me. I wasn't aware of this unsaid hierarchy, which is like feudalism in a way. I also wasn't aware of how one is perceived because of their onscreen presence and characters."

She credited her survival more to luck than to any particular presence of mind

In the same conversation, Kritika shared that one principle has remained non-negotiable for her and that is the kind of women she agrees to portray. She has consistently turned down roles she finds regressive, even at the cost of big film opportunities.

She said, "I'm a feminist. I say it proudly. I care about how female characters are portrayed onscreen." She further shared, "Even on TV, I stayed away from kitchen dramas or shows where certain regressive themes were glorified. I tried to do the more progressive stuff." AGENCIES



'A chance to set a precedent'

Mercedes Kilmer opened up about her father Val Kilmer's AI-powered final role

LOS ANGELES: Val Kilmer's daughter Mercedes came out in defence of the late Hollywood star's AI-generated appearance in the upcoming indie film 'As Deep as the Grave', saying the technology offered her father a chance to set a precedent on actors owning their digital likeness.

Kilmer, who died last year after battling throat cancer, was cast as Father Finton, a Catholic priest and Native American spiritualist in the historical drama, but was too ill to shoot his role. With the cooperation of his estate and Mercedes, the filmmakers used generative AI to include him in the film, in which his character appears for over an hour, according to director Coerte Voorhees.

Speaking on the "Today Show", Mercedes said the project had evolved well beyond a workaround for her father's illness. "It started off as a way to overcome the limitations of his illness, but then it



The late Hollywood actor died last year after battling throat cancer

evolved into something that he really was like, 'Oh, wait. I have a chance to actually set a precedent,'" she said.

She acknowledged the mixed reaction to her father's AI recreation. "It's kind of fallen into two camps. People who maybe have a more precarious position in the industry and are worried and see AI as a threat, which is absolutely valid and younger people, younger actors and musicians."

Mercedes, who is a musician, said she understood the anxiety but argued that engaging with technology proactively was preferable to avoiding it. "We have to contend with this technology one way or the other. And avoiding it, it's not necessarily the way. It's much

easier to structure the rights if you proactively license something," she said.

It isn't the first time Kilmer has turned to AI to navigate the effects of his illness. Diagnosed with cancer in 2014, he had previously partnered with UK-based company 'Sonantic' to create an AI-powered voice when he reprised his role as Tom 'Iceman' Kazansky in 'Top Gun: Maverick' in 2022.

The trailer for 'As Deep as the Grave' - which tells the story of Ann Axtell Morris, one of America's first female archaeologists and her excavation of the Canyon De Chelly in Arizona was recently unveiled at 'CinemaCon' in Las Vegas. In it, Kilmer appears at various ages, including as a ghost-like figure and as a young man. PFI

Kapil Sharma announces World Laughter Day special on Netflix



MUMBAI: Netflix will mark World Laughter Day with a special episode of 'The Great Indian Kapil Show', featuring host Kapil Sharma alongside popular influencers Samay Raina and Ranveer Allahbadia.

The episode, streaming May 2, will also feature regulars Sunil Grover, Krushna Abbashek and Kiku Sharda in their signature roles during a segment called the 'TGIKS News Debate'.

Sharma said the special episode was planned to keep the audience's love for the show in mind. "The love we have received from the audience for our show motivates us to keep giving them fresh and entertaining content. On the occasion of World Laughter Day, we have planned a special episode with Netflix - natural, fun and full of laughter," he said.

"This time, Samay and Ranveer are also joining in their own style, making this celebration even more engaging. We want people to enjoy this day by laughing along with us," he added. PFI

The special episode to have popular influencers Samay Raina and Ranveer Allahbadia

'JUICE UNCLE' ACTOR PARK DONG-BIN FOUND DEAD AT 56

The cause of the South Korean veteran actor's death is still unknown

Veteran South Korean actor Park Dong-bin, popularly known as 'Juice Uncle' from a viral meme, died at the age of 56. On Wednesday, he was found dead at a restaurant he was about to open in Pyeongtaek, Gyeonggi Province. The police found no evidence of foul play or a suicide note and the cause of death is still unknown. The officials are still investigating the circumstances of his death.

On Thursday, the Pyeongtaek Police Station said that an acquaintance helping him with the new restaurant business found Park's body in the evening, around 4:25 pm the previous day, in the Jangsan-dong area. According to the authorities, the ini-



tial assessment didn't hint towards any criminal activity.

A funeral wake has been arranged at the Anseong Civic Funeral Hall in Gyeonggi Province. The funeral has been scheduled for 8:30 am on Friday. His remains will pass through the Yongin Forest of Peace before being buried at the Woosung Memorial Park. The actor had tied the knot with actress Lee Sang-yi, his junior by 12 years, in February 2020. He is survived by her and one daughter. Park had recently appeared on a TV show and opened up about his love for his daughter, who had undergone surgery for a congenital heart condition.

Park gained a lot of popularity on

the internet after a scene from the 2012 'MBC' drama 'I Love You, I'm Sorry' (also known as 'Did we love?') went viral. The moment where his character spits out orange juice in shock became a social media sensation, giving him the nickname 'Juice Guy'. Born in 1970, he debuted in the 1998 film 'Shiri'. He went on to feature in several noteworthy projects, including 'Volcano High', 'How to Keep My Love' and 'The Huntresses' and TV shows like 'Rustic Period', 'Immortal Admiral Yi Sun-sin' and 'The Great Wives'. He married actress Lee Sang-yi in February 2020. The couple has a daughter together. AGENCIES

Christopher reveals why 'The Odyssey' had to be shorter than 'Oppenheimer'



to see what he has crafted with this adaptation. However, Nolan has also acknowledged the significant pressure surrounding the project, given its imminent release.

Speaking to the 'Associated Press', he said, "There's a massive amount of pressure. Anyone taking on 'The Odyssey' is taking on the hopes and dreams of people for epic movies everywhere and that comes with a huge responsibility." Reflecting on his earlier work, particularly his acclaimed 'Batman' trilogy, he added, "What I learned from that experience is that what people want from a movie about a beloved story, a beloved set of characters, is they want a strong and sincere interpretation. They want to know that a filmmaker has gone to the mat for it. I really tried to make the best film possible."

Interestingly, Nolan's continued commitment to shooting on celluloid has shaped the production in a notable way. 'The Odyssey' becomes the first Hollywood feature to be shot entirely with IMAX cameras. However, this technical ambition also influenced the film's runtime. Due to IMAX projection limitations, the film had to be shorter than 'Oppenheimer'. AGENCIES

AAMIR KHAN SAYS QSQT 'HAPPY ENDING' WAS NEVER RELEASED

Mansoor Khan's 1988 directorial debut was a pathbreaking film

Mansoor Khan's 1988 directorial debut 'Qayamat Se Qayamat Tak', starring Aamir Khan as Raj and Juhi Chawla as Rashmi, was a path-breaking film not only because it was a much-needed young love story in the 1980s era of low action entertainers, but also because of its unexpected ending. Both Raj and Rashmi, after eloping to the jungle away from their disapproving families, are killed for their rebellion in the end.

It's a lesser-known fact that Mansoor's father and legendary filmmaker Nasir Hussain insisted on a happy ending for the film. "While we were writing, he wanted a happy ending. So, he told Mansoor to shoot both the endings - happy and sad - and then they'd decide in the edit which one works better," Aamir revealed recently.

Mansoor revealed that in the



alternate happy ending, instead of Juhi's character getting shot and then tumbling down the rocks to death, it was Goga Kapoor's character, Randhir Singh, who met that fate. "In the happy ending, the killer points the gun at Juhi when she's screaming, 'Raj! Raj!' And then he hears somebody scream, 'Rashmi! Rashmi!' That was Goga Kapoor. This guy is a

greater threat, so he shoots Goga Kapoor," said Mansoor.

The filmmaker recalled how none of the actors could take that ending seriously as they kept cracking up while filming the final mid-closeup shot of Goga's character breathing his last. "He has blood coming out. For the mid-closeup shot, everybody came around to see him. But before I can call action, one of the actors starts laughing. Not the spot boy, one of the actors! It happened two or three times. Then Goga said, 'Saalon main mar raha hu, tum has rahe ho!' (I'm dying here and you guys just keep laughing!). That was the proof that it wasn't working," added Mansoor.

Mansoor and Aamir chose to shoot the happy ending because Nasir Hussain kept insisting on it consistently, from the writing stage to the filming stage. AGENCIES

